Where Gold Wept

A tale about free will

Foreword

As I was writing Where Gold Wept*, a peculiar fear crept into my mind: that you, my dear reader, might believe this story to be the sole fruit of my imagination. Not to steal any credit, I will confess upfront that I merely added a few touches of my own to the work of a far more gifted storyteller:* History*. When I first set out to write a tale about free will, I intended it to be just loosely based on the episode of mansa Musa's famous pilgrimage; but the more I researched this period, getting lost in the markets of Timbuktu and the intrigues of the Cairo Citadel, the clearer it became that my humble imagination couldn't match reality. What I uncovered was the stuff of fairytales: a fabulously rich king arriving from a far-away realm; slave-warriors ruling from a towering citadel; a City of the Dead coming to life… To my dismay, I even had to exclude some incredible bits of history from my narration – but I couldn't bear to discard them entirely. That's why I've added footnotes, to expand on real events, shed light on little known facts, or simply share fun anecdotes. Of course, you are free to skip them and read* Where Gold Wept *as if it were only fiction – as if no lavish caravan had ever arrived from Mali in the year 1324 AD…*

Chapter 1

Panting, the young prince kept climbing block after block, exhilarated by the effort. He no longer felt exhaustion, only the thrill of rising ever higher. Sooner than he expected, he reached the flat summit and smiled in triumph. From up here, the caravan, the town of Giza, and the Nile looked so small, so vain. On his way to the Great Pyramid, a local peasant had tried to stop him, warning that it was cursed – but that view was surely well worth any curse. He wondered if this was what it felt like to be Allah watching over his creation from above. He wished he could stay atop this pyramid forever; once he climbed down, he knew he'd shrink back into a meaningless black dot called Maghan Keita. As he lay down on the warm, ancient blocks, Maghan realized that this pyramid would outlive him and everyone else… Shying away from that humbling thought, he sat up and spotted Cairo sprawling in the dusty horizon. Finally, after long months of crossing the Sahara, the caravan would make its first stop in this city, and rest for a few weeks before resuming its journey bound for Mecca.

Maghan had heard that Cairo was the greatest city in the world, the *queen of cities*. He tried to picture Timbuktu beside it and compare the two, but couldn't tell which one was larger. Looking down at the caravan, he realized that perhaps it too was larger than Timbuktu. It felt like half of Mali had joined this pilgrimage: some twenty-five thousand men, women, and slaves, forming the largest caravan in living memory – and the most dazzling as well. Its tents were made of silk, held up by pikes of solid gold. Maghan's father Musa, the mansa of Mali, had wanted his caravan to put Africa's sun to shame. This pilgrimage was the occasion for him to show his empire's fabulous wealth to the world. Back when the caravan was being assembled in Timbuktu, the young prince had been surprised that they'd bring gold as a sign of wealth. Why gold, and not something more

precious like salt? When he was told that, where they were going, salt was abundant but gold was rare, he was still not satisfied. How could gold be more precious than salt, if it couldn't be eaten?

The next morning, the caravan stopped in the *City of the Dead*, a vast cemetery where thousands of tombs, great and small, formed a town of their own with silent streets and squares. There were also many inns established around the tombs, making it the ideal place to accommodate pilgrims in large numbers: those could afford it stayed at the inns, while the others could sleep under the dome of mausoleums, in the quiet company of long-dead sultans. Mansa Musa met innkeepers until noon, always paying them three times the usual fare. Once accommodation for his enormous caravan was settled, he set out to the city of Cairo, accompanied by his son Maghan, his highest dignitaries and his royal guard. He had been invited by the sultan to the Citadel, the seat of Mamluk power. As the Malians were approaching one of Cairo's gates, flanked by two massive towers, they saw it being hurriedly closed. Musa decided they'd keep going to that gate anyway and wait. After a moment waiting under the scorching sun, prince Maghan heard a strange noise and cupped a hand to his ear. It sounded like there was some kind of commotion on the other side. He also noticed that the sentinels atop the ramparts looked agitated, running back and forth between both sides of the wall – until they all suddenly stood straight and still. A huge silhouette had appeared between the crenels. Even from afar, it was obvious the man dwarfed common soldiery. With awe, Maghan realized he was seeing a Mamluk for the first time. Mansa Musa steered his black horse forward, all the way between the two towers, to talk to this Mamluk.

'Brother, won't you welcome a few pilgrims into your city?' he asked in almost perfect Arabic. 'I thought the Mamluks prided themselves as the *protectors of the pilgrims*.'

'Your majesty speaks true', the Mamluk officer replied, 'we are the protectors of the pilgrims. That's the reason why we cannot open our gates. There's a rumor circulating about you, that you'll distribute gifts to everybody. I know not where it originated, but it has contaminated the whole city. Behind this gate, thousands have gathered, expecting gifts. Please accept my apologies as the commander of the city guard. I should have ordered the streets barred long in advance. If you will please wait a moment, I will at once order my men to scatter these bums.'

'We shan't wait. Open the gate, now!'

'Your majesty, if we do, the people will—'

'Open the gates', the mansa insisted. 'Or should I tell the sultan that his commander of the city guards declined hospitality to pilgrim guests?'

The officer uttered a quiet prayer, turned around and bellowed orders. Thousands of voices yelped in expectation as the thick door wings creaked open. Musa was first to enter, ahead even of the royal guard. The city guard strove hard to contain the populace to both sides of the avenue and let the Malians pass unhindered, but they were far outnumbered. They were forced to take a step back, then another. The Malians moved forward despite the crowd appearing like it would swallow them whole. Wherever Mamluk warriors came as reinforcement, the people shrunk back in terror, but they were too few. It took a single instant, at a crossroad, for the dike to break. Hundreds of men, women and children closed in at once on the mounted pilgrims. The royal guard rushed to protect Musa and Maghan, but the mansa ordered them off, letting these people approach him and even touch his horse and his legs. Once he was fully surrounded by hopeful souls, he opened a bag on his

saddle and drew a handful of gold pebbles. For a split second there was silence. The human flow clotted still. Musa took a moment to savor the impatience seething around him, then threw the pebbles. The crowd screamed like it was the Day of Judgement. A thousand hands stretched to the mansa, and everyone elbowed their way forwards against everyone else. The other Malians started distributing gold as well. The rumor had been true. Mansa Musa wanted the world to know the generosity of the Malians.

Maghan froze at first, intimidated by all those begging hands. But he quickly composed himself and threw a handful of pebbles, trying to aim for women and children. The lucky few who caught the gold looked back at him wanting more, while everybody else stretched their hands farther in the hope to be next. He made another throw, making sure everyone would receive their share, but new faces kept appearing every second. As he kept throwing and throwing, he started enjoying it, intoxicated by the gratitude stirring around him. He wondered if Allah feels this way when men pray to him. *Is this what it's like to be loved?* Now he was throwing faster and further, playing a kind of unspoken game with the crowd. He no longer felt his arms – only the joy. The people here were so nice, he thought, and Cairo was so magnificent. This was what he had hoped to find when leaving Mali. After visiting Cairo, Medina and Mecca, why return home? Why not continue travelling everywhere from Grenada to Guangzhou, giving gold and happiness to the whole world? This was so much fun! When his bag emptied, a servant immediately handed him a second. He opened it, put his hand inside, and started. Here too, the gold pebbles felt wet under his fingers – wet with tears. With each throw, they grew wetter. *Those cursed visions…* He had never told anyone, but the destiny of most objects he touched unfolded in his mind and soul. Those gold pebbles were no exception. He could never focus long enough to know why they would shed tears, but he knew they weren't tears of joy.

The Malians slowly made their way to the Citadel, which loomed over the queen of cities with its stark, thick ramparts. The closer he came to it, the more Maghan thought it looked ugly and ominous. He changed his mind once inside. Behind those rough walls hid a shining city-above-the-city, full of exquisite palaces and mosques[1]. Entering it felt like uncovering sweet fruit beneath the spiny skin of a prickly pear. It was also heavenly quiet, far above earshot of the screaming crowd below—but it didn't stay quiet for long. As soon as the Malians had arrived on the main esplanade, a small army of porters appeared from all directions to take care of them. The horses and camels were brought to the stables; the gold and other supplies taken to safe vaults deep under the Citadel; the royal guards led to the barracks, and the dignitaries housed in quarters for honored guests. Meanwhile, mansa Musa and prince Maghan were shown the way to the sultan's main residence, the Striped Palace (so-called for its stripes of yellow and black marble) where they were invited to spend their stay in Cairo. Staying here was an immense honor, but the prince smiled at the thought that those yellow and black stripes were fitting for rich Malians. As he walked through the arched corridors of the palace, Maghan wondered whether the sultan regarded his father as an equal. If not, then who ranked higher: a mansa or a sultan? Which empire was greater: Mali or the Mamluks'? When Maghan entered his room, he became sure the Mamluk empire was the greatest: the carpets, the rosewater basin, the buffet of dates and pastries, and that huge bed made his room in the

1 The Pyramids of Giza were originally covered in white limestone, but sultan Al-Nasir (whom you will meet shortly) had that limestone taken down to be used for building mosques. Sadly, though the Citadel of Saladin still stands today, most of the magnificent mosques and palaces from that time have since been demolished and built over.

Timbuktu palace feel like a barrack. He wanted nothing more than to jump on that bed – the first proper bed he'd seen in months – but there was no time to rest now. The sultan was waiting.

Chapter 2

The afternoon had just begun, but it felt to Maghan as if a whole day had passed since he'd entered Cairo, with a week's worth of emotions: the joy of giving away gold, the pain of foreseeing tears, the amazement of seeing the Citadel. And now, he was to accompany his father to meet the Mamluk sultan. He had just enough time to spray his face with rosewater, eat a few dates and put on his best clothes before a delegation of Mamluk officers came to escort him and Musa to the Great Iwan. On the way, the prince couldn't help staring up in wonder at these imposing Mamluks, with their brown and blond and even red hair, which he'd never seen before. Why did they look nothing like the black haired, dark eyed people of Egypt? When they entered the Great Iwan, the most important hall in the Citadel, Maghan felt minuscule underneath its massive red pillars[2] and celestial green dome. This room was twice as large as any he'd ever seen. At the other end, sultan Al-Nasir stood up from his throne. Like his fellow Mamluks, he looked foreign to the people he ruled. He had prominent cheekbones and narrow eyes – which, Maghan had been told, were the features of those eastern barbarians who had conquered half the world[3]. Maghan focused. Now was not the time to succumb to daydreaming and commit a faux pas. As etiquette required, he remained a few steps behind while his father and Al-Nasir came face to face in the middle of the hall. The two rulers looked at each other in tense silence. Then Musa said, 'Brother, are you expecting me to bow down to you?'

'I expect it of all those who come before me', Al-Nasir replied.

'Allah is the only one I bow to. I can get on my knees, curb my back and touch the floor in front of you, but it'd be to Allah, not to you.'

Al-Nasir paused a moment, then smiled. 'In that case, brother, I'd be bowing with you!'

At this, both men laughed the tension away. At Musa's signal, three slaves came forward carrying a heavy load between them. It was a gold boulder as large as a pregnant belly.

'Here is for you', Musa said. 'I give you the second largest gold boulder molded by the hand of Allah ever to come out of our mines. I would have offered you the largest one, but it is so massive it could not be carried such a distance and had to remain in my staples.'

Musa had hoped Al-Nasir would ask him why he kept it in the staples, so he could boast it was used to tether his favorite horse[4]; but the sultan had guessed it was used this way, and didn't want to hear the mansa say out loud that he'd rather leave the world's largest gold boulder to a horse than giving it to him. Instead, Al-Nasir made his own signal to a servant, who brought him a sword on a satin cushion. Its curved blade was inlaid with fine calligraphy and its knob, curiously, was a dinar coin.

'Musa Keita, my friend, it has been over two years since I was first informed that you'd undergo your pilgrimage, and that I'd receive you in Cairo. I had prepared for you much the same gifts I

2 These red pillars, like the white limestone of the pyramid, were reused from Pharaonic times.

3 Al-Nasir had a Kipchak father and a Mongol mother.

4 This huge tethering boulder would eventually be sold off by a later mansa of the Keita dynasty, during the Mali empire's decline. I'd like to believe it has never been melted or broken, and is currently hidden somewhere, waiting to be found…

gave to your predecessor mansa Sakura[5] when he came to Cairo for his pilgrimage two decades ago: an Arabian mare, fine clothes, ivory items… But when I heard of what you did this morning to my people, giving them gold so generously, I thought these petty gifts were not worthy of such a generous Muslim soul as yourself. That's why I decided to give you the most precious item I possess: the *Sword of the Coin*. Here it is. Its blade was swung by my father to cut down many foes in battle, and that coin—'

'Would it be enough to repay all the gold?'

Maghan was sure he had just thought that silly question in his head, but apparently it had escaped from his mouth. His father threw him a look such that he wished he could vanish on the spot. He mumbled, wondering how to amend for such blatant disrespect. If the sultan had ordered him lashed or beheaded, he'd have accepted it gladly. Instead, Al-Nasir laughed.

'Brother Musa, you've got a bold son. Don't scold him – I respect courage more than anything! If you could make him less frail, he'd make a fine warrior.' Then turning to the prince, 'Now, young Maghan – that's your name, isn't it? – I was just about to explain that yes, this coin could repay all that gold. Surely, you know that my father was nicknamed *the Thousander*? No? The story is known everywhere except in Mali, then. When my father was about your age, he'd become the strongest and bravest Mamluk trainee in living memory. The sultan at the time was so impressed that he bought him for a thousand dinars – twice the price of any elite Mamluk. Many years later, after my father had become the sultan, he managed to find one of the thousand coins that had bought him. He put it on this sword so it would bring him luck in battle. It did win him many a victory. Now, lad, do you understand?'

'Yes, but… How could your father be bought?'

'Because he was for sale, of course! Why, don't you know anything about the Mamluks?'

Maghan blushed. He knew that the Mamluks were praised as the world's mightiest warriors, but was there anything else to know? His father grunted in embarrassment.

'We, the Mamluks, started as slaves', Al-Nasir went on explaining with pride. 'Each generation of Mamluks buys new slave children from all corners of the world and trains them to fight from the earliest age; once their harsh training is complete, they are bought, freed as Mamluk warriors, and repeat the cycle. This is why you won't find stronger warriors than us. This is how we defeated the Mongols and the Crusaders[6]. We grew up in chains, blood and sweat instead of silk, wine and rosewater. We didn't just seize power – we earned it! In a world ruled by well-born dynast, we rule through our own merit. Even all the gold of Mali cannot be worth a single coin that bought a good Mamluk.'

Al-Nasir then turned back to Musa, forgetting about the young prince. During the welcome feast that followed the meeting, neither Musa nor Al-Nasir would take another look at him. They seemed to get along well, chatting about past battles and the current difficulties facing the slave trade. This left Maghan to ponder over what had happened this morning. Why would the gold weep? How

5 Sakura, a former slave, usurped power from the Keita dynasty. As mansa, he expanded the Mali empire from the Atlantic Ocean to the West to the Saharan city of Takeda to the East. He was killed while returning from his pilgrimage by Qu Keita, who reestablished his family's rule. It is a fun coincidence that Malian names such as Sakura, Keita or Takeda are also Japanese names.

6 It took no lesser foe than Napoleon to inflict a final defeat on the Mamluks at the Battle of the Pyramids, ending five centuries of Mamluk rule in Egypt. And to give full credit to the Mamluk warriors who faced Napoleon: they were armed with swords against cannons.

could the joy turn into suffering? Suddenly he had an idea, and decided to leave the table early, knowing his absence would go as unnoticed as his presence. A servant accompanied him back to his room, but as soon as he was left alone, he got out and slipped into his father's room. He didn't need to look too long until he found the Sword of the Coin on its satin cushion. His hand was shaking as it neared the Coin. Was it going to cry the same tears as the gold pebbles? He took a deep breath and clasped it. At first, he felt only the soft, comfortable satin cushion—a violent blow ripped it off the sword. A tear fell down Maghan's cheek as if he'd been torn away from a loved one's arms. He kept on clasping. Now he felt worthless, utterly worthless, like a beggar who had once been a king. Unable to bear it anymore, he let go of the coin and caught his breath. Both the gold and the coin were heading to misery, but he was still clueless why.

Chapter 3

Maghan woke up before dawn the next day and sprayed his face with rosewater. His reflection in the basin looked back at him with red, swollen eyes. Nightmares had been haunting him all night long – vivid images of people crying scorching tears of melted gold, of gold pebbles raining down on the city like a hailstorm, of children drowning in the Nile overflowing with liquid gold… He was relieved to hear the muezzins calling for the dawn prayer, setting him free from that interminable night. The prince turned in the direction of Mecca and, bowing down on the carpet, begged Allah to spare the people of Cairo from whatever woe was about to befall them—was that even any use? After all, if the future could be seen, didn't that mean Allah had decided the course of everything in advance? After prayer, he went to climb atop the ramparts of the Citadel and observe the city sprawling below. No one was crying, no pebbles were raining down, and the Nile's water was still greenish. Would any woe happen at all? Maghan could only hope not, but so far, all his predictions had come true. What truly scared him was not that something bad was coming – tragedies happen every day – but that he alone knew about it and couldn't tell anyone. As a child, he had learned to keep his unique visions secret after seeing a group of poor men accused of practicing sorcery being hung by his father. Yet he was not versed in any kind of dark magic, and surely Allah wouldn't have given this ability to him without a good reason. Perhaps his role in the world was to stop sparks before they'd grow into wildfires. If he wanted to save the people of Cairo, he needed to know exactly what would afflict them and how it would come about, so he could warn the sultan without raising suspicions. To gather the information he needed, he knew he'd have to leave the Citadel and use his special touch on gold and other objects… Before he could coward and think himself out of this plan, Maghan went to the Citadel gates and handed a guide a coin to lead him to the City of the Dead – to see a friend.

'Don't you know where your friend is staying, my boy? We're going in circles', the annoyed guide asked once again.

Maghan was looking around from his saddle in fascination. The City of the Dead had come to life: from inside towering mausoleums, he could hear children laughing and parent arguing; some families had even hung wet laundry between the ornamental crenels. Hopefully the deceased didn't mind their rest being disturbed. The prince pointed to a squatted tomb, and the guide stopped his mule.

‘We’ve passed this tomb two times already!’, the guide exclaimed. ‘But fine. I’ll keep your horse and wait for you here.’

‘Oh… No need for that. I’ll manage to return to the Citadel on my own.’

To drown any objection, Maghan slipped yet another coin into the guide’s hand. He waited for the man and his mule to be out of sight, then stirred his horse in the direction of the lower city.

While the City of the Dead had been full of sound and bustle, the streets of Cairo were eerily quiet and empty this morning. Perhaps people were thinking work could wait after they’d received multiple years’ worth of salary the day before. Maghan tethered his horse on a square near an unguarded gate and walked alone into the urban maze, touching the walls, the doors and even the pavement on his way. They say walls are mute and indeed, they didn’t reveal much to the prince – which was good news, for at least the houses wouldn’t collapse. He still hadn’t gathered a single clue, nor met a single soul. At last, the prince saw a wizened old lady turning at a street corner and thought of a plan: he’d kindly ask her to carry her bags or help her walk, obtaining lots of information from touching the fabric of her bags and clothes. He called her in polite Arabic, but as soon as she noticed him, she hurried back the way she came. The same happened with a little boy playing ball a few streets further. Puzzled, the prince stopped in the middle of the deserted street, wondering if Cairo’s population had already started to vanish—A hand poked his legs from behind. Turning around, he saw the little boy from earlier. And behind him, his father, his brothers, his uncles and his cousins all the way down the street, each carrying a bag at arm’s length. The prince turned away but on the other side, the old lady from earlier had brought her children and grandchildren with their own bags… The commotion attracted yet more people, and soon the word spread to the whole neighborhood. *Gold*. Maghan froze with fear. How could he have hoped to go unnoticed in Cairo, with his black skin and his silk clothes inlaid with golden beads? Those beads, in fact, were starting to be torn away by childish hands. The prince’s gaze fell down the dark maws of those gaping bags. He didn’t even have enough gold to fill any of them. The more he stood there and did nothing, the more agitated the crowd grew. What to do? What to say? What—Reason, incapable to save him, made way to beastly panic. The prince fled, elbowing his way forward as hands tried grabbing his clothes, his arms, his hair… He turned to the next street, but the crowd followed him. As he ran, he looked up in hopes to find the citadel above the roofs, but there were only indifferent clouds and minarets. There was no finding his way back… Passing by an ajar door, he entered it and slid the bar behind him. Brute fists pounded at the locked door and voices screamed in frustration before at last, he was left alone. The prince laughed in relief at first, then broke down in tears. There was a bitter irony in the salty taste of his tears: all that the people of Cairo had managed getting out of him was salt, which in Mali was more valuable than gold.

Only after a moment did it occur to Maghan that he might not be alone inside here. He wiped his tears and, as his eyes adapted to the dimly lit room, the darkness surrounding him turned into a silvery shine. Exquisite basins, vases and figurines glittered on their shelves. They were, in the prince’s eye, far more beautiful and precious than gold. Why would the silly people of Cairo run after some crude yellow metal, when such refined artifacts could be found in their city? He startled. Just a few steps away from him, he noticed a small man sitting at a table covered with tools.

‘Do all men cry like women, where you come from?’, the man asked.

The prince didn’t know what to say. Those cutting and crushing steel tools on the table did not look reassuring. How could this man’s thick, dirty hands create the shining perfection on the shelves?

‘You are one of those Malians, aren’t you? I was in the crowd yesterday when you entered Cairo. You looked quite cheerful, even more so than the people who caught your gold. So why do you come crying in my shop?’

Maghan told him how the crowd had been so close to ripping him apart, but his pathos didn’t meet much pity.

‘Allah be praised that my front door can’t be smashed easily! You worried they’d tear off your limbs, but image if they had managed to break in here! All my livelihood would have been looted and, while at it, they might have taken my life as well. Do you ever think what consequences your actions may have? When you tell me that you are the mansa’s son, I believe you. As a prince, you believe you are the hero of some fairytale, so whatever you do can’t be wrong – never mind the common folk.’

‘I’m sorry I trespassed into your shop like this, but… how else was I supposed to escape from them?’

‘Next time they ask you for gold, act like a man and admit you have nothing to give them. Think how your father would have sent those bums away!’

The prince lowered his eyes. He could easily imagine the booming voice of his father echoing through the streets, sending everyone running home in fear. A prince of Mali shouldn’t escape like a prey, nor venture alone into a foreign city. The thought crept into his mind that perhaps Allah had made a mistake at his birth, injecting his cowardly soul into the body of a prince, while some other newborn had received the soul of a prince.

‘Looking at me’, Maghan sighed, ‘these people didn’t see Maghan Keita. They only see a gold fountain.’

‘Looking at me’, the coppersmith replied, ‘people don’t see Muhammad ibn al-Zayn. They only see hands that can craft them a pretty vase. So what? I only ask my wife and my daughter to see me as Muhammad ibn al-Zayn. To everyone else, I ask for dinars in exchange for my work.’

Now that he knew Muhammad ibn al-Zayn’s name, Maghan felt confident enough to draw closer to the shelves and admire his metallic craft in all its delicate details. His eyes quickly stopped on a magnificent basin standing out from the rest. He was sure never to have seen anything so beautiful. Its surface was alive with characters and beasts of silver and gold.

‘Is this basin to your liking?’, ibn al-Zayn asked as to any client. ‘It’s yours for ten gold dinars.’

‘Ten gold dinars? But it’s worth so much more!’

Muhammad ibn al-Zayn didn’t seem to be the kind of man to laugh often, but this made him chuckle.

‘You are my first client to haggle prices upwards, not downwards. It’s obvious you never had to earn your bread. Makes me glad to be ruled by Mamluks; harsh they may be, but at least they understand the realities of life.’

‘To me, it’s the people of this country who don’t understand life. How can a few yellow metal coins be more valuable than a basin, which is not only beautiful but also useful?’

Two hard knocks at the door interrupted their discussion. Ibn al-Zayn went to open and found four soldiers of the Malian royal guard on his doorstep, as well as a Mamluk warrior who demanded explanations. Weighing each word carefully, the coppersmith told him that, seeing the prince fleeing the savage crowd, he had offered him refuge in his shop and pushed his assailants away at the risk of his own life; he concluded that Allah – not himself – was to be thanked for keeping the prince safe. This embellished story, crafted with as much meticulousness as his vases and basins, pleased the Mamluk who gave him one gold dinar for his troubles. Ibn al-Zayn had expected his words to earn him as much, but the Malian guards did not want to be outdone by a Mamluk and offered him a fist-sized gold nugget (though they hadn’t understood a single word he had said). Muhammad ibn al-Zayn could not believe his luck. His own reflection on the nugget looked back at him with awe from a golden world. As Maghan left the shop, the coppersmith gave him a look of greedy gratitude, just like those wretches who’d begged him earlier that morning. The prince felt betrayed. He had assumed this man was different.

‘You see me as nothing but a gold fountain too, don’t you?’, he blurted at the coppersmith in anger. ‘I do hope that gold brings you tears!’

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Mansa Musa was crouching before the Quran, immersed in the sacred verses. A few steps away from him, his son was standing still. A full hour passed, then perhaps another, and the mansa never once turned his eyes away from the holy pages. Maghan was growing impatient and nervous, yet he didn’t dare fidgeting or moving at all. He had guessed the reason his father had him come here. Being forced to wait interminably was only the premise. At last, Maghan could not bear it anymore.

‘Father, shall we study this surah together?’

As a response, his father began to psalmody the verses aloud, making it impossible for Maghan to speak again lest he interrupted the word of Allah. Only once he reached the end of the surah did Musa carefully close the book and look up to scrutinize his son.

‘Such is the price Allah is making me pay for listening to your mother. I knew I should have forced you to study the Quran from dawn to dusk. Instead, she let you frolic like a gazelle and when she left us, your aunt Qassa took care of you with as much negligence. Now, I see the result leaving of your education in the hands of women. You covered our whole nation with shame this morning. You haven’t given anything to these poor people; worse, you’ve fled them like a coward. You ran away from generosity itself. At least that’s what I’ve been told. Was I lied to?”

‘Father, these people—’

‘Answer me. Is it true that you ran away? Is it true you refused to give them gold?’

‘I didn’t have any gold to give them.’

‘Little imbecile! What image of our people are you giving to the world and to Allah?’

‘Father, I have foreseen… I have the intuition that our gold will bring grief to everyone we give it to.’

‘You listen to your *intuition*? Intuition is the Devil whispering in your ear! Against your intuition, there’s the truth Allah has revealed in his book: if you run away from generosity, your flight will lead you straight into the flames of Hell! I do not wish you to end up in Hell, so from now on, I’ll be forcing you to give away gold. When we arrive in Medina and Mecca, you’ll have to give away gold until your hands are all scratched and bloody. That will teach you to be generous!’

‘Is it truly generosity, if I don’t have the choice?’

The prince did not flinch as his father stood up in rage to grab a stick. Not wanting to disappoint him with more cowardice, he took all the hits.

Chapter 4

Upon entering the Citadel’s library for the first time, Maghan felt intimidated. It was as though the countless centuries-old books were gazing down on him like a crowd of scholars taunting the unlettered he was. He had indeed never been much of a reader, but with no fault of his own; books that made it across the Sahara to Mali were scarce, and most of them were copies of the Quran. He didn’t know so many different books even existed. Was a single lifetime enough to read all of them? He walked along the shelves, gently running his fingers on the leather bindings. Touching each book gave him a warm feeling, that of being chosen and appreciated by future readers. He smiled. The books weren’t anymore looking down on him, but he was looking up to them. He began reading the titles and author names aloud, unsure which one he’d pick first—someone shushed. He startled and turned. A bloated, sullen-looking man was sitting at the back of the room, reading a large volume. The prince felt irritated, as if a thief had just stumbled upon his treasure trove.

‘Don’t you shush me’, Maghan grumbled. ‘It’s impolite.’

‘Impolite! And what would you call speaking aloud in a library for no good reason?’

‘Who are you to talk to me this way?’

‘My name is Al-Mustakfi of the House of Abbas. I am the caliph.’

Maghan opened his mouth and closed it. The *caliph*? How could that stranger be claiming the highest title in the Islamic world? Hadn’t the Abbasid caliphate been extinguished when the Mongols took Baghdad? Yet this Al-Mustakfi sounded eerily sincere, and his spoken Arabic was too elaborate for a mere commoner. The prince shivered, turned away and hurried to pick the volume nearest him, a medical treatise by Maimonides. He spent the rest of the day nervously turning its pages without truly reading them, trying to forget the presence of that self-proclaimed caliph across the room. The next day, Maghan returned to the library and found the bloated man again. They didn’t exchange a word, only a venomous look. The prince sat as far away from him as possible, but even at a distance, it was hard to escape from his spleeny aura. That evening, Maghan collapsed on his bed. He had tried hard to read a history book, but the lines had been blurry in his eyes. Suddenly he heard his father lash out in his adjacent room. He laid his ear on the wall to listen. ‘That would be the same as insulting him right on!’, Musa yelled. ‘No, anything but that! What, plain gold, for his highness? Go find something else before I beat you. Show me—no, that’s not refined enough—I don’t care who made it—That’d be a worthy enough gift for your peasant mother, not for the

caliph!' Maghan started. Was that shushing bookworm truly the caliph? And he'd been treating him like a worthless bum! How could he have been so careless? The next day, after a sleepless night, he entered the library and went straight to the table at the back, determined to apologize. Before he could say anything, Al-Mustakfi raised his sullen eyes to him.

'You are Maghan Keita, son of Musa Keita, I presume? I see you coming here for the third consecutive day, which begs the question: why don't you go out and explore Cairo?'

'I… um… should I, your highness?'

The caliph rolled his eyes at the sound of *your highness*. 'Your fellow countrymen certainly seem to be enjoying themselves out there. I hear they've been buying compulsively from every store they find. Merchants are inflating prices five times for them, but these barbarians are buying anyway. Why aren't you with them?'

'I… I didn't feel safe leaving the Citadel anymore, your highness.'

As if he'd heard something silly, Al-Mustakfi grunted and bent back to his book. Maghan didn't move. A long moment passed in awkward silence before he found the courage to ask: 'What kind of present would please your highness? My father has spent all night looking for a worthy gift in vain.'

The mouth of the caliph twisted, and he slowly raised two reproachful eyes to the prince.

'You may forget about a gift. Your father craves an audience with me, so I may confirm him as the legitimate ruler of Mali, but only the sultan decides whether this audience shall happen. I have no say in the matter. Is Al-Nasir saying your father's gifts aren't worthy enough for me to accept an audience? He has once given that same excuse to a Syrian emir – before he invaded his lands.'

'Oh… but surely the sultan doesn't plan on conquering Mali, does he?'

'Maybe not, but if he has decided this audience shan't happen, it's useless coming to me to sway that decision. You can tell your father to stop looking for a gift. None will ever be enough.'

'That's unfair! We have so much gold we could fill this library up to the ceiling. Wouldn't that be enough?'

'One day, you will learn there are things that gold can't buy.' The caliph had a wistful smile. 'You came asking me what kind of present would please me? Well, it's also something gold cannot buy.'

'What it is?'

The caliph sighed. 'My *freedom*.' He stretched an arm and exposed his wrist. 'Do you know why blood is the color red? Physicians say it's because it contains iron. For me, that is the iron of chains. I wish I could replace the blood flowing through my veins. I won't be free so long as I'm cursed with the blood of the caliphs of old Baghdad[7]. You cannot change my blood, can you? Then stop bothering me.'

'If I may… Why would your highness not want to be the commander of the believers?'

'You foolish little barbarian, do I truly look like I'm the commander, here?'

'Well… Um…'

7 After the sack of Baghdad by the Mongols, the heirs to the Abbasid caliphate fled to Cairo, where the Mamluk sultans used them as puppets to legitimize their rule. The fact that the descendants of the caliphs of Baghdad, from the tales of *One Thousand and One Nights*, lived in the Citadel, adds to the fairytale aspect of this episode of History.

Al-Mustakfi gestured Maghan to lean forward and spoke with a low voice. ‘You’ve seen the sultan, haven’t you? His Mongolian face says it all: his ancestors were yurt-dwelling savages; his father was a slave, whose parents probably sold off in return for some firewood. Does this sound like the making of a sultan ruling over Egypt, Syria and the noble Hedjaz? Meanwhile, here’s a man whose ancestors ruled half the known world and whose bloodline goes back to the Prophet’s family. How fortunate for the sultan, then, to hold such a man at the point of his sword! When Al-Nasir rose to power, I was forced to confirm him as the rightful sultan of this land; since then, I exist solely to provide legitimacy to his reign. He might as well sit on my back to use me as a throne. Through me, the Mamluks are not anymore barbarian brutes ruling by reason of force – they’re the pious protectors of the caliph. If my father had known that the Mamluks would keep his line alive to steal our legitimacy, the same way that farmers breed cows to steal their milk, he wouldn’t have fled to Cairo. Better stay in Baghdad to be slaughtered by the Mongols!’

‘Yet your highness is the heir of the old caliphs of Baghdad. That means something!’

‘Of course it does, otherwise I wouldn’t have to live with the sultan’s blade forever under my throat. So scared is Al-Nasir that a rival might use me to claim the throne, he forbade me from leaving the Citadel – for my protection, he claims. So here I am, living a life that knows no hope, no adventure, no dream, no success nor failure. I’m on a flat road to the grave, spending my days reading, absorbing all the world’s knowledge which I shall never be allowed to use.’

‘Well, then, wouldn’t you…’ Maghan paused. He had said ‘you’ instead of ‘your highness’, yet that felt more appropriate. Better not remind him of his cursed blood. ‘Wouldn’t you help a barbarian prince navigate this ocean of knowledge?’

Reluctantly, the caliph stood up and began pointing up and down at various books, praising their authors, recounting their lives and deeds. Hearing him, it seemed to Maghan that the tempestuous lives of these authors made a far more interesting story than anything they wrote. The caliph, as he went on and on, started realizing that he was enjoying himself for the first time in many years. He had finally found someone to talk to. Eventually Maghan chose to pick a book by Omar Khayyam, because his life and character had sounded so intriguing. Thus began the routine of the following weeks. Everyday Maghan came to the library and plunged his mind into the pages of Aristotle, Averroes, Maimonides, Avicenna… Through their words, these great men made him feel understood, enlivened and enlightened, like better fathers than his own. Whenever he stumbled upon a word or sentence that he didn’t understand, he asked Al-Mustakfi for help. From their time spent together among the books, an unlikely friendship grew between the young prince and the middle-aged caliph.

A few weeks had passed when the caliph vanished without explanation. Maghan had just begun a book compiling traveler accounts of old Baghdad and had lots of questions for his friend. Three days later, he was still absent. When the muezzins began calling to the Friday prayer, Maghan closed the book and stood up, sighing at the empty table at the back of the room. Tomorrow, the caravan would resume its journey to the holy cities, and he couldn’t bid the caliph farewell. After squeezing the volume back between its two neighbors, he looked up at the shelves rising to the ceiling and bit his lips. He had only opened a thousandth of these books, yet he wanted to say goodbye to them all.

The mosque floor was packed for this special Friday prayer. This was the occasion to celebrate the Malians resuming their pilgrimage journey. Mansa Musa and prince Maghan were sitting in the front row, alongside sultan Al-Nasir and his own sons. The imam who arrived to lead the prayer before the many rows of faithful had a sluggish gait, and his white robe molded a sagging belly. Maghan started. *There he is!* When the caliph bowed down to the carpet, everyone followed. He then rose the steps to the pulpit and, before delivering the Friday sermon, paused to look at his audience. The Malian pilgrims were gazing up at him with glowing eyes, eager to hear the very successor to the Prophet speak. He knew he would disappoint them. With all his scholarly knowledge, he had the ability to share groundbreaking insights and interpretations, but there would be no such sermon. Instead, he started with a pompous praise of sultan Al-Nasir, followed by an inflated elegy of mansa Musa, saying the good people of Cairo thanked Allah with every breath for having brought such a noble, pious, generous and exemplary Muslim monarch to their city. Maghan knew his cultured friend would never have written such banal speech. He was reciting words written for him by some purposely talentless hands. As the prince looked around at the audience, he saw everyone acquiescing politely at the praises of Musa's proverbial generosity. He remembered his visions of the tearful gold – could they have been wrong? No, as vague and mysterious as his predictions could be, they never once had failed to happen. Maghan started fidgeting back and forth on the praying mat, impatient for the service to end. What if he had spent the past weeks comfortably reading books, while thousands of souls had been crying for help to a deaf Citadel? He wanted to see for himself whether the people of Cairo were indeed praising the Malians with every breath – or rather cursing them. The memory of him cursing that poor coppersmith who had let him take refuge in his shop came back with a sting. Today, his last day in Cairo, was his last chance to apologize to… He felt growing shame with each minute it took him to remember that coppersmith's name was *Muhammad ibn al-Zayn*. As soon as the prayer ended, Maghan rushed to his room in the Striped Palace and filled his purse with thirteen golden dinar coins, as well as a handful of gold pebbles to give if begged on the way. Then, he approached an elite Mamluk named Baybars, a close companion of Al-Nasir. He had been appointed him chief protector to the Malian royal family during its Cairo stay. Even for a Mamluk, Baybars was broad shouldered and imposing, and it took Maghan a long moment to gather enough courage to address him.

'O Baybars', the prince began timidly, 'do you know how to reach the shop of a coppersmith named Ibn al-Zayn?'

'Muhammad ibn al-Zayn? Of course. I know in which hole each rat dwells in this city. Shall I take you there?'

'I'll give you a gold pebble if you do.'

'Keep your damn pebble and follow me.'

Before Maghan noticed it, his fingers were fidgeting with the gold pebbles in pocket, ready to throw them at the inevitable crowd; but the city was eerily empty and quiet. His guts tightened. At this time after the Friday prayer, he'd expected people to be strolling around the streets, filling jars at the fountains and relaxing in the gardens. Occasionally, there was a sullen boy, a beggar in rags or a mean-looking woman, slipping away as soon as they saw him with Baybars. No one came asking for gold. An odd smell was oozing from some houses. On some walls, there were half ripped signs were large-writ sentence bits such as 'like a benevolent Muslim' or 'for our children' still screamed

in the void. In a shaded alley, not too far from Ibn al-Zayn's workshop, Maghan stopped in astonishment. There, in the gutter, was a knuckle-sized gold nugget. He picked it up but dropped it almost instantly: the feeling of worthlessness was too acute to bear. Once they reached the workshop, Baybars knocked so hard with his giant fists the whole facade trembled. The coppersmith looked through the peephole and opened immediately – as one does when a Mamluk officer is at one's doorstep. Before Ibn al-Zayn could say anything, Maghan hurried inside and emptied the thirteen dinars of his purse on the table.

'O Muhammad ibn al-Zayn, I came here to apologize. You offered me refuge in your shop and instead of thanking you, I insulted you.'

'You didn't need to come', the coppersmith replied hurriedly.

'Well, I don't think my words make enough of an apology. I remember that you had a splendid basin. Do you still have it? Oh, yes, here it is! You're selling it for ten dinars, don't you? Let me give you thirteen dinars for it instead! Is that not enough? I have some gold pebbles too… Here, those pebbles together should be worth about twelve dinars, so you'll have twenty-five dinars instead of ten. Please, accept this money as my apology.'

'I don't care about forgiving you. Now please leave.'

'Please. In a book I read last week, there was a beautiful sentence that said: *the one who forgives is greater than the one who seeks forgiveness*. Please forgive me.'

'Listen, boy, if you want to laugh at me, go mock someone else!'

'I'm not mocking you. You can even keep the basin if you don't want me to have it, but please accept my twenty-five dinars.'

'With your miserable twenty-five dinars, how am I supposed to feed my wife and my girl?'

'But you sell such a masterpiece for only ten dinars.'

'Why, I'd sell it for a hundred, not less!'

'A hundred? But a few weeks ago—'

'A few weeks ago, there wasn't...' The coppersmith stopped and resumed on a different tone: 'Say, Maghan Keita, would you like me to show you some more affordable items? If you won't mind following me to the backroom, you'll find some that may be to your taste.'

Maghan followed him into a room that would have been dark if not for the silvery glitter of many vases, cups and statuettes lying around on worktables and rough shelves. Only after seeing the coppersmith look over his shoulder like a hiding prey did Maghan understand the reason behind the sudden invitation.

'Up in the Citadel, you must have plenty of food, no?', the coppersmith whispered wearily. 'If you have some food on you right now, some bread or dried fruits… I'll let you trade it for any one of my works.'

'Why, I don't think I do.'

'You don't? But you can come back tomorrow, can't you? I'll wait for you. You can bring bread, vegetables, meat… Whatever you want! Oh, they'll be so happy, my wife and my girl… It's been two days since they haven't swallowed a thing. Now they're too weak even to cry.'

Maghan also looked at the back-room door to make sure Baybars was not listening, then asked the question that had been weighing on his mind since he saw the deserted city: ‘Was it the gold?’

‘What, our hunger?’

‘Is everyone starving because of the gold?’

‘Not up in the Citadel, I suppose. But down here… You really don’t know what’s going on? Let me tell you. There aren’t enough gravediggers to bury all the corpses. Some dead people are just left rotting in their homes, while others… I’ve heard some families are selling them as food or eating them directly. And yes, your people are to thank for this. You’ve brought us so much gold here that no one can afford bread anymore.’

‘I don’t understand. I thought we had made everyone rich.’

‘You brainless brat! Where you come from, gold is abundant – does that make everyone in Mali rich?’

‘That’s not the same. In Mali, people are rich if they own salt and cowries, whereas here—’

‘Here gold was valuable because it was rare. People used to be paid in gold for their work, but now that gold’s worthless, what can they be paid with? Not in silver or copper, since their value is pegged to gold. Not with food, since those who produce it can’t be paid either: the baker can’t sell bread, because the miller can’t sell flour, because the farmer can’t sell grains. And the farmer can’t grow grains in the first place, because he can’t pay for equipment, fertilizers, labor, cattle… That made food scarce like gold used to be. When the crisis began, I still managed to feed my family by bartering a vase for a loaf of bread or a flowerpot for a piece of dried meat, but now nothing’s as valuable as food. What are my pieces of shiny metal worth to a starving soul?’ Again, the coppersmith switched his tone. ‘I’ll wait for you tomorrow! You like my large basin? Bring me enough vegetables to fill it, and it’s yours! You’ll come back tomorrow, won’t you? You can even come back this evening, if you can. You and I are friends, aren’t we?’

For a moment, Maghan was determined to run back to the Citadel, take all the food he could carry with him and bring it here before twilight. He would save this family – but let countless other families starve. He wondered if there was a way for him to save everyone. *Yes, of course there is!*

‘I will return at once to the Citadel’, Maghan declared, starting to exit the back room, ‘and tell the sultan everything you told me!’

The coppersmith grabbed the prince’s forearm so firmly it could have shattered the bones inside.

‘You fool! Do you want me killed?’

‘Too late to worry about that’, Baybars said behind them.

With one hand the giant Mamluk grabbed the small man by the collar and lifted him above the ground.

‘I could have heard you from a mile away. Did you think you were doing a good deed, telling such horrors to that innocent boy? The Malians are guests of our sultans on their holy pilgrimage – and you mean to tell them they are responsible for people dying and eating each other? If some people like you are starving, it’s only because you refused to work. Haven’t you read the signs our sultan placarded on every street, encouraging you to join a communal farm and grow food for the people?

You have, but you never cared about the greater good – only about money. Not only that, but you have the audacity to blame our Malian guests for being hungry, instead of your own greed, selfishness and sloth.'

'My lord, how could I have worked on a communal farm for free, when I have a wife and a daughter to feed?'

'Oh, you have a precious wife and a precious daughter to feed! What about everyone else's wives and children? The selfish bastard you are wasn't interested in feeding them – and now you cry when your own family is starving.'

Baybars dropped Ibn al-Zayn to the ground like a dirty rag and lifted a fine cup from a nearby worktable to admire its detailed engravings. 'You're a talented man, Muhammad ibn al-Zayn. Some say you're the best coppersmith in the empire. Everyone in Cairo knows your name – so you'll make a fine example.' He chuckled. 'In a way, you'll die a hero: when the people see you being cut in half, it'll learn to stay in line. You couldn't live for the greater good, but at least you'll die for it.'

'Mercy, my lord! What will become of my wife and my daughter?'

'Even in a time like this, a woman always has something to sell, hasn't she?'

The Mamluk kicked Ibn al-Zayn hard in the loins. The poor man twisted on the floor and raised wet, supplicating eyes to the prince. Maghan froze in terror. Baybars, who was still holding the cup, used it to hit its creator on the skull and knock him unconscious. He left the room carrying his prey on one shoulder like a hunted deer but turned back on the doorstep when he noticed Maghan had remained petrified.

'What's the matter? I won't hurt you. You're the sultan's honored guest.' He made a few steps further to the front door, then stopped again. 'Oh, isn't that the basin you came here for? You paid for it, so take it.'

As if that was an order, and not daring to do otherwise, Maghan went to the basin and lifted it from its shelf with trembling hands. It was much heavier than he expected—and now the smell of incense filled his nostrils. He felt holy water splashing from above as Christian princes were being baptized inside it, and then quiet admiration by travelers from all corners of the world[8]… Thus did Maghan realize this basin's value was far beyond a hundred dinars, or a thousand – but its creator would never know it. The next day, while Maghan left Cairo with the golden caravan, Muhammad ibn al-Zayn was cut in half on a public square.

Chapter 5

On the long way from Cairo to Medina, didn't feel the scorching sun rays, the heat, the thirst, nor the dullness of the long road. He felt only guilt and self-hatred, endlessly ruminated. The scene of that poor man's arrest replayed in his mind, again and again and again. Every time, he imagined himself acting differently: boldly standing between Baybars and Ibn al-Zayn; throwing himself at Baybars's feet to pathetically implore his mercy, trying to bribe him with gold, rebuking him in a

8 Known as the *Baptistery of Saint Louis*, Muhammad ibn al-Zayn's masterpiece is now exhibited as the centerpiece of the Islamic Arts division in the Louvre. It is especially famous for having been used as a baptismal font for many French princes, including future Louis XIII, despite coming from the Islamic world. How it made its way from the Mamluk empire to France is still a mystery. Perhaps that journey did really start with Maghan Keita picking it up in Cairo. Therefore, next time you visit the Louvre, don't forget to say hello from the future to our dear Malian prince.

princely way, throwing the basest insults at him… A thousand things he could have done, when he had just stood by and watched. He let the memory gnaw on his brain as a form of expiation. When the caravan was crossing the Sinai desert, the other pilgrims were looking around restlessly from atop their camels, hoping to catch a view of the sacred mountain; only the prince kept staring at the sand below. *Thou shall not kill*, Moses had said here – but Maghan felt like he had killed Muhammad ibn al-Zayn with his silence. The most painful part of the memory was Baybars saying 'I won't hurt you'. If there had been no danger in saving Ibn al-Zayn's life, why didn't he? It was on this conclusion that his rumination cycle always ended – and started over again. Until the slender dome and minarets of the Prophet's Mosque in Medina finally came within sight of the caravan, the prince had played millions better and fairer pasts in his mind, but none of them would ever repair the past.

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Their reputation had preceded the Malian pilgrims in Medina. When they arrived, news had reached Medina of their proverbial generosity, but not yet of its consequences. For days, the locals had been busy preparing for the coming of the golden caravan. Through tough wrangling, the men had agreed on which spot each family would stand along the path while the caravan made its lavish entrance; the women, meanwhile, had stopped doing their usual household chores to spend their days sewing bags; even the children had been preparing, playing at tossing ossicles at each other to train catching gold pebbles. When the much-awaited caravan was spotted at the horizon, the whole city held its breath like a hunter about to shoot a white deer. The sun was at its zenith. The muezzins atop their minarets made the most hurried call to prayer ever heard before hurtling down – not that anyone would be joining the noon prayer anyway. The bulk of the caravan remained outside the city to make camp in the desert outskirt, while the Malian elites went on to perform their show of generosity. They were to parade through the city three times before stopping at the caravansary. The moment they crossed the gates, the carefully assigned spots along the road for each family broke apart. Everybody scrambled to hold their gaping bag nearest a Malian horse or camel. Some women pulled their infant up from the ground to save them from the stampede with one hand, while they kept holding a bag in the direction of the caravan with the other. Some men (and women) resorted to pulling the others by the hair and clothes to gain one meter of ground, before being beaten at this game in turn. In the middle of all this rode Maghan, mounted upon an immense white stallion. His father had given him the largest horse in the caravan, the only one strong enough to be loaded with six sacks full of gold pebbles – twice as much as the other carried. Musa had told his son that, by the time the parade ended, all six sacks must be empty. Else, he would go to Hell. Maghan began throwing gold by the armful, almost falling down his saddle from the weight. The worse was not the pain in the arms and back, but the gold's own pain crying through his skin. It didn't take long to the people of Medina to notice that boy on a huge horse showering twice as much gold as the others. Hundreds flocked to the prince. One man in the crowd drew his dagger and tore up one of the six sacks. So much gold poured out at once that his foot shattered underneath. He screamed in pain, but no one heard him. When the procession finally reached the caravansary, Maghan was out of breath and holding up tears. He was too small to dismount such a towering horse on his own, but Musa lifted him off the saddle himself and squeezed him tight against him. The pride he felt from his

father, in that instant, was more valuable than all the gold in the world. Instead of going to Hell, he had risen to Heaven.

That evening, Musa and Maghan had been invited to diner by the Mamluk governor of Medina. As they were sitting around a large pot of finely spiced lamb, the mansa took out a small piece of gold from his purse.

‘My son had taken with him twice as much gold as anyone of us’, he explained, ‘and achieved to empty his entire load. Except for this little nugget. A servant found it hiding alone at the bottom of a bag. All the rest, he had given to the good people of this holy city. Isn’t my son the most generous, blessed soul?’

‘I saw him today’, the governor said, ‘and indeed, I was impressed by his selfless drive. I didn’t see him resting for a second. His little arms have more strength than they look! You’ve raised a fine Muslim, O Musa Keita.’

‘Praised be Allah, I have!’ Then Musa turned to Maghan to hand him the nugget with a smile. ‘Here, you forgot that one. Give it to an old lady tomorrow.’

Maghan wanted to smile too but struggled not to wince when grabbing the gold. Yet beyond the weeping, he now heard something else – the faint, unintelligible sound of his own voice.

During the week the Malians spent in Medina, Maghan had little time to himself. His father insisted he accompany him everywhere: praying before the Prophet’s grave, overseeing the resupply in water and food, visiting the sick… In all these activities he did not say a word nor have a word to say, serving as his father’s glorified shadow. Ibn al-Zayn’s ghost still haunted him. There was no library to hide and drown his sorrows in, but standing at his father’s side brought him some comfort. The Malian pilgrims did not fail to notice Musa’s change of attitude towards his son and gave him more respect than they ever had. Still, Maghan longed for some solitude. On the last evening in Medina, while the whole caravan had gone to sleep early, he finally found himself alone. He bribed the men guarding the caravansary to let him leave without asking questions and went to explore the city on his own. It was a moonless night, and the darkness was camouflaging his black skin from greedy passersby. For every house on his path, he stopped to lay a hand on its dried mud walls, burning with curiosity. These were the same walls that, seven centuries prior, had seen the Prophet himself walk by. Maghan was hopeful that perhaps tonight, just tonight, touched things would show him the past instead of the future – and thus what Prophet Muhammad looked like. The figure of Muhammad had been omnipresent in his life; as a baby, an imam had sat by his princely crib reciting *Muhammad is Allah’s messenger* in his small ears; as a boy, half of all the stories he ever heard were about him. His words and actions were cited all day long; his name was chanted five times a day atop every minaret; but it was all faceless. Maghan flexed his muscles and focused his mind to try glimpsing at the missing face of Allah’s messenger, but there was only the future – and this future was dust. He felt the weight of huge scary machines crumbling all in their path. In a few centuries, every house and every mosque in Medina would be gone, levelled to the ground. Not even the tombs of the Prophet’s companions and family would be spared. He didn’t hear screaming nor smelled blood. This wasn’t frenzied ravage by heathen invaders, but cold, calculated demolition

by Arab Muslims[9]. *Won't these holy places mean anything to them anymore?* Maghan wondered. He shivered. If gold and holy relics could become worthless – what about his own worth?

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Mecca was reached a few hard journeying days later. When the holy city was spotted on the undulating horizon, the whole caravan roared in joy. Maghan rejoiced with the others, though in truth he was quite underwhelmed at the sight. Mecca was a small desert down, further dwarfed by the tall rocky hills surrounding it. After crossing half the known world, the prince had expected more. The Holy Mosque was as wide as the rest of the city, consisting of a flat roofed prayer room, five minarets and a square courtyard enclosing the Kaaba. Maghan had imagined the Kaaba was a cube as gigantic as the pyramids, but it was no larger than an ordinary house. Still, his heart pumped with awe at the sight of its ancient black stones.

The Malian elites went straight to the caravansary, in the courtyard of which the governor had organized a welcome banquet, but the pilgrims could hardly eat. They were too awed and excited to swallow anything. Maghan went to his room and collapsed on the bed. Tired as he was, however, his heart wouldn't stop racing to let him sleep. Then he started. Something was amiss in Mecca. *Where was the crowd?* Perhaps that was the real reason why Mecca had seemed so small in his eyes. Not one begging soul. It felt like they had sneaked inside the holy city like thieves. Maghan closed his eyes and sighed. His last thought before finally falling asleep was that hopefully, the gold wouldn't weep here.

The next morning, every barber in Mecca was busy shaving the heads and cutting the nails of every male Malian pilgrim. Maghan could not resist touching his smoothed head, tickling at the novel sensation. Once shaved and abluted, the Malians were deemed purified enough to enter the Holy Mosque, clad in plain white sheets. Musa led the way into the mosque and towards the Kaaba. He was as bald and plainly dressed as the hundreds of fellow pilgrims behind him, yet one could tell from his confident gait that he was their leader. Maghan was walking at his father's side, trying to mimic his royal allure. Upon stepping into the courtyard, the prince felt overwhelmed with holy dread. He stared gaping at the Kaaba, oblivious of everything else around him until he bumped into something – a tall ginger man. The man frowned, then yelled at the prince in his own language. Musa stepped up to defend his son and, without anyone remembering who shoved who first, a brawl broke out between the Malians and the white pilgrims in the courtyard. Maghan shrunk as men were pushing and hitting each other all around him, throwing unintelligible insults, forgetting in what a sacred space they were. At last, a regiment of Mamluks arrived, drew the two brawling parties apart and evacuated the mosque. Musa and Maghan were closely escorted to the house of the governor for safety.

9 The Saudi government has destroyed many sites dating back from early Islam to avoid them being worshiped like idols, but also to make room for building larger mosques and luxury hotels.

A Mamluk warrior was posted at the room's window, and another at the door. Maghan and Musa both waited in silence, wondering how a pure and pious experience had turned sour so quickly. When the governor came in, he ordered the two warriors to leave before speaking in an equal tone.

'There is nothing to worry about. No one is targeting you, O Musa Keita. If these wretches had known you were the ruler of a great empire, they wouldn't have dared attacking you. You can resume your pilgrimage safely. I have ordered the Holy Mosque closed except to Malian pilgrims. If you or your son have been harmed, let me bring in my personal physician.'

'We are not harmed, thanks to Allah. But we won't be resuming our pilgrimage yet. If Allah permitted this brawl happen in the holiest of places – that must mean He thought us undeserving to approach the Kaaba.'

'Oh, brawls like this happen in the Holy Mosque almost every moon, if only you knew! And you were lucky that no blood was spilled, for that happens often. Sometimes, pilgrims from two different sects cut each other down over the most minor differences. Sometimes, like today, brawls ignite for no reason at all[10]. I would not worry about divine punishment.'

'It doesn't matter. Allah must be punishing me because we didn't distribute gold to the people of Mecca.'

'Then let Him punish me, not you. I am the one who ordered the Meccans to stay at home when your caravan came. I had reports that three people died in a stampede when you entered Medina, and a dozen were wounded. I didn't want the same happening here.'

'I knew you have given that order, but despite this I didn't knock on every door to give the Meccans gold in their homes. Such is my sin. Let it never be said that Malians are not generous!'

'Please, you have already proven your generosity well enough in Cairo and Medina. If you give gold to commoners here, I will confiscate it from them before it does any harm.'

'What harm? If I gave you gold – which I will – you would be happy, wouldn't you? Let the Meccans know that joy too. If Allah has put so much gold under the ground of my empire, it's for me to redistribute it to all Muslims and make them all rich.'

The governor remained silent, and Maghan bit his lips. Neither of them would dare telling him why the gold had wept in Cairo. After a few hard strokes of his beard, the Mamluk found a way out of this tense situation.

'Perhaps the pilgrims you encountered this morning will leave Mecca and bring home dreadful opinions about Mali, which could then spread around the world. For the sake of your people's impeccable reputation, perhaps it would be good to apologize to them, and compensate them for their trouble.'

'You are right. Please find every white pilgrim who was around the Kaaba this morning and bring them to me.'

A few hours later, around the banquet tables still set in the caravansary courtyard, mansa Musa treated the pilgrims he had quarreled with to a feast of his own. The tall ginger man was seated in the place of honor between him and Maghan. After everyone had eaten their full, Musa had the food

10 A quarrel did really erupt near the Kaaba between the Malians and Turkish pilgrims. Both parties even drew their swords. Fortunately, mansa Musa saw what was happening from a window overlooking the Holy Mosque and ordered his subjects to back away before blood could be spilled.

replaced with gold nuggets and asked his guests to fill their purses as they had just filled their stomachs. Once nothing was left but white tablecloth, he joked that desert hadn't been served, and the tables were covered in gold once again. Everyone laughed except two. The first was the chief treasurer. He approached Musa, whispering in his ear that they had just given away half the gold left in the caravan; although his majesty's largess was praiseworthy, perhaps his majesty should consider tempering—Musa sent him away with a swing of a hand. The second was prince Maghan. He was thinking of Ibn al-Zayn, a man who had worked hard all his life, covering his hands with thorns to create perfection out of crude metals, saving well-deserved dinars for his family – yet he had seen his family starve and was brutally slaughtered. Meanwhile these pilgrims were going to return home as the richest men in their country, for the sole merit of reacting badly to a boy bumping into them. Why had Allah punished the righteous and rewarded the wrongdoers?

The next day, the Malian pilgrims finally completed the ritual of circumambulating the Kaaba. After they had walked in circles seven times, the moment came to kiss the Black Stone, that piece of meteorite set into a corner of the Kaaba[11]. Musa went first, followed by Maghan. The prince leaned forward, his lips touched the surface – and he felt the exalted kisses of millions of future pilgrims as if it was on his own skin. So strong was the emotion that he froze and had to be carried out the mosque. Until nightfall, he was unable to speak at all. Everyone around him attributed this reaction to extreme piety, which inspired them deep respect for the prince. Musa couldn't stop boasting about his son being the sincerest of believers. Soon tales of a black prince with a most fervent faith reached the ears of imam Ibrahim, the most renowned scholar in Mecca. Ibrahim offered to give prince Maghan advanced lessons in Islamic law, to help him one day become the finest of Muslim rulers. Musa happily accepted.

The imam and the prince were now sitting face to face on a mat, with a volume of hadiths opened between them. Ibrahim had been talking for hours about the authenticity of such and such hadith, while Maghan had tried his best not to look bored. At the end of the course, the imam asked his student for questions. Maghan did not need to think long.

'Is it true that Allah rewards the righteous and punishes the wrongdoers?'

This surprised old Ibrahim. He had just taught complex jurisprudence to this supposedly godly prince, only to be asked such a naive question.

'It is true indeed', he replied. 'Allah is the most just. Looking around you, you may see bad things happening to good people or good things happening to bad people, but what happens in this life doesn't matter. The real retribution comes in the next life. The few years we spend in this world pass like an instant compared to eternity in Heaven or Hell.'

'I know this – but what makes a deed good or bad? My father says I must give away gold if I don't want to go to Hell. But if I'm doing it just to escape hellfire, am I truly being generous? Is doing something good out of genuine kindness truly the same as doing something good out of fear?'

'Yes, because you always have the choice not to do good. Allah has given us free will.'

11 It is debated whether the Black Stone is truly a meteorite. Even if it isn't, its history is no less stellar. Through the centuries, it has been stolen, smashed and even bombarded, but also fervently kissed by countless pilgrims. If the Black Stone did indeed fall from outer space, perhaps it came to our world to experience all the hate and all the love that humans are capable of.

‘He has – and yet He punishes us if we don’t behave the way He wants.’

‘Without free will, your good actions wouldn’t truly be your own. Would you rather be a puppet?’

‘If Allah is omnipotent, doesn’t that already make us all puppets?’

‘The fact that Allah has planned the whole course of the Universe does not contradict humans having free will. You are still responsible for your own choices. Allah does not decide for you – but He already knows each choice you will make.’

‘If this is true, then Allah knows that some souls will inevitably go to Hell – but creates them anyway. Why did He create free will, if it’s to doom countless men and women to an eternity of suffering? Is it even fair to punish sinners, when it’s Allah who both enabled and predestined them to sin?’

The imam struck his beard, uneasy. Two types of students generally asked him these questions: the best and the worst. Which one the prince was, he could not yet determine.

‘Maghan, as a boy your age, I suppose you like to play?’, he answered, content with the logic he was about to outline. ‘Think about your favorite games: the rules have been decided in advance and the players either win or lose – yet you still play them. You’d never play a game where all moves are scripted and everyone is sure to win, because there’d be no thrill, no challenge, no joy in victory. It’s much the same with life. Ask yourself: would life be worth living without any challenge? Would souls deserve Heaven, if they were guaranteed to go there? If Allah has created an imperfect world, with sin and free will, it’s to give man a goal and life a meaning.’

‘If so, once we reach Heaven, does life become meaningless?’

‘If you reach Heaven, you’ve already accomplished your life’s meaning – and deserve to reap the rewards.’

‘Didn’t you say earlier that our lifetime is nothing compared to eternity in Heaven? After a billion years reaping the rewards of a few decades – relaxing, drinking wine, laying with virgins – wouldn’t existence start feeling meaningless again? Wouldn’t we want new challenges and goals, rather than mindlessly keep on playing a scripted game we cannot lose? With your logic, we should rather go to Hell!’

‘Allah forgive us! I had been told you kissed the black stone with never-seen-before devotion, but now I’m starting to believe your sincerity was just an act to fool everyone. How shameful. Allah can decipher your soul, and there will be no fooling Him on the Day of Judgment.’

Maghan looked away from Ibrahim’s gaze and said nothing, not understanding this sudden burst of anger. Why couldn’t this supposed expert answer his question? The imam mistook the prince’s silent reaction for self-abasement and felt, rising inside his loins, the sadistic pleasure of crushing a child under his authority.

‘This blasphemy shan’t go unpunished, Maghan Keita. Wait until I tell your father about it! Yes, I will tell him. Don’t give me that look. You don’t want it, but it’s for you own good. It’ll teach you! I will tell him tomorrow—’

‘Tomorrow, my father was planning to reward you with a fist-sized gold nugget. If you make him angry, he won’t give it to you.’

Maghan had been tempted to cry and beg for forgiveness, but halfway through Ibrahim's logorrhea he remembered what Muhammad ibn al-Zayn had told him the first time they met: how would a prince of Mali behave? That fist-sized nugget reward was a bad lie (the mansa would pay the imam a lot more) but it worked as intended. Now he saw the roles reversing and was tempted to smile in triumph. Ibrahim twisted nervously on his mat.

'I was going to say that if you go now to the Holy Mosque and repent before Allah, I won't need to tell your father."

'So now that you fear my father won't give you any gold', Maghan pressed on, 'telling him is not the right thing for you to do anymore? What's the moral difference between acting by fear of not being paid and acting by fear of going to Hell?'

The imam stood up without caring to respond and went for the door. Unwilling to let a boy have the last word, however, he turned back on the doorstep to say: 'It's not because free will enables us to do bad, that we shouldn't do good. I hope Allah will have time to forgive us all before the Day of Judgment, for it will come sooner than you think.' Long after the imam had left, and until the night prayer was called, Maghan kept sitting pensively. His predictions often reached many centuries into the future, so he knew the Day of Judgment wouldn't come so soon. *Then surely Allah will have enough time to forgive us all*, he mused.

At this sweet hour of dusk, the desert air was just the right temperature, halfway between the arid heat of day to the freezing cold of night. Maghan was walking alone in the desolate outskirts of Mecca under the steep rocky hills. He had been going on such outings every evening, coming back when the night prayer was called from the Holy Mosque's five minarets, cherishing these moments of quiet solitude. This would be his last one, however, for tomorrow the caravan was to leave for home. After over a year of traveling, the young man had trouble picturing himself back in Mali, resuming the routine of court life. There were so many other lands to explore, but no more money to reach them. Mansa Musa had given away so much of his wealth in Mecca that barely enough was left to finance the return journey. He had violated the governor's orders by organizing lavish gold giveaways for the poor, and bought books on jurisprudence, gifts for the sultan, mansions to house future Malian pilgrims… When his treasurer threatened to resign if he spent one more ounce of gold, the Mansa started giving away slaves instead. To all religious and secular officials in the city, he had given at least two female slaves. Imam Ibrahim had received seven. He'd also gifted castrated slaves as harem eunuchs. Then, as an act of piety, he decreed the manumission of all his remaining slaves on the condition they convert to Islam, which many gladly did—The noise of galloping hooves pulled Maghan away from his thoughts. He looked around and shivered. It was getting dark and cool. Perhaps his father had sent men looking for him. A light suddenly blazed a short distance away. Like a naive butterfly he ran towards it and found a tall black man holding a torch. From the stank of sweat, he guessed that was one of his father's slaves.

'Did you come looking for me?', the prince asked. 'It's me, Maghan Keita.'

The man kept staring at him without saying a word. Perhaps he smiled, though it was hard to tell as he lifted the torch higher towards the sky. The sound of hooves came closer and closer until two dozen horsemen appeared in the torchlight. The foremost stallion reared, and from its saddle a feminine voice asked: 'Is that him?'

‘Yes, sister’, the torch-holding slave answered, holding the flame so close to Maghan’s face he winced from the heat.

‘Don’t burn the master, idiot!’

The prince looked up and started. He had never seen a woman in armor. With her stern face and her hair flowing in the desert wind, she looked just like how he had always imagined warrior-queen Kahina[12]. Around her were many other women on horseback wearing misfitting armor, as well as a few men. He recognized his father’s slaves – escaping. He did not remember being pulled off the ground. A swift hand, trained by years of forced labor knotting ropes, tied him at the back of a saddle, and off the runaway slaves vanished into the night.

Chapter 6

The sun rose above the Arabian desert, with a few morning rays finding their way inside the cave. The escapees had lit fires and were cooking freshly hunted birds. Maghan was sitting at the back of the cave, exhausted from the sleepless overnight ride. The leader of the band, that Kahina-like armored woman, came to sit next to the prince and handed him a cooked bird’s leg.

‘Here is for you, master. You should eat before we sleep. When the sun sets, we’ll continue to Jeddah.’

‘Thank you’, Maghan said awkwardly, unsure whether to be thankful.

‘Is the food good enough for the master?’

This woman kept calling him *master.* Was it a habit from her enslaved days? Maghan remembered Ibn al-Zayn’s advice again and wondered how his father would have acted in this situation. After some hesitation, he said with a tone intended as confident: ‘If I’m your master, then bring me back to Mecca.’

‘We can’t do that, master. We are going to Jeddah. We say you are our master, and you will say we are your slaves, but now we are free.’

The prince only grew more confused. They had not tied his hands, nor taken any of the gold he was wearing. It appeared almost as if he truly was their master. That made him feel as much dread as if he’d been treated harshly, like a sacrificial animal knowing it owes its lavish living to its upcoming slaughter. The woman sensed his fear.

‘I was your age when I was captured from my village. My name is Inari.’

‘Inari? My late mother was named Inari.’

‘I know, I used to be her maid. Poor woman. You lost her too early, but I’m sure her spirit has never stopped watching over you all these years. You cannot see her, but she is here with you now and forever. Because she was a good woman, I won’t hurt her son. Understand? Unless you become violent, I won’t hurt you.’

12 Kahina, or Dahya, deserves more fame as one of the great women of History. During the Islamic conquest of North Africa, she managed to unite the Berber tribes against the Arab invaders. Though initially victorious, she was ultimately defeated and died sword in hand.

‘Someone already told me that’, Maghan sighed, remembering Baybars. He had been told his mother’s soul was up in Heaven, but at this moment he preferred adopting the pagan belief that her spirit was indeed here at his side.

‘We are now halfway to Jeddah’, Inari went on. ‘It is a great port city, wherefrom many ships sail to Africa. When we arrive in Jeddah, you will say you are our master freeing us, and with that gold you have, you’ll pay us passage on a ship. Understand?’

Maghan was tempted to just nod and go along. After all, this plan was simple, and after he had sent the escapees off the shores of Arabia, he was free to go back to his caravan. Yet now he felt worried for Inari’s fate, as if her name did make her family.

‘After you land in Abyssinia or Zanj, what will you do?’

‘Go home.’

‘But Africa is immense, and your home is on the other side of it. What if you can’t reach it?’

‘Then we’ll find another land to call home. Or we fail and die – but at least we’ll die free.’

‘I don’t want you to die.’

‘Your father gave me to imam Ibrahim. Fortunately, I escaped before he could touch me, but do you see the sister over there? Her name is Sassouma – and Ibrahim did rape her. We’d rather die than live such a life!’

Maghan looked down, not daring to face Sassouma, nor Inari. As he had been Ibrahim’s student, he felt as though he carried part of the blame. *It’s not because free will enables us to do bad that we shouldn’t do good*, the imam had said. Was raping these women good? Was escaping to freedom bad? The prince may have wondered out loud, or maybe Inari had guessed what was on his mind, because she said:

‘We chose freedom, but other slaves didn’t follow us. My sisters who have chosen to stay slaves will live only to be raped, but at least they’ll be sheltered and fed, and they preferred that. There are also many brothers and sisters who converted to Islam to be freed. Them, they won’t be slaves no more, but they betrayed our home faith and made our ancestors’ spirits weep. These brothers and sisters made their choice, and we made ours. Understand?’

Maghan silently acquiesced without fully understanding what Inari meant. The fires were shut, and they went to sleep. As the prince wasn’t tied, he considered stealing a sword and—he knew he’d never do such a thing. He fell asleep too, as if he was one of them.

Maghan and the runaway slaves had hoped to pass the gates of Jeddah unnoticed. After all, many African pilgrims went to and from Mecca every day. Inari and the other women had even abandoned their stolen armor to cover themselves in Islamic veils. That was not enough to fool the Mamluk officer at the gate, however. He ordered the group to halt and unfolded a letter.

‘*From Hajji Musa Keita, mansa of Mali*’, he read. ‘“*Twenty-four slaves, including twenty females, have escaped from Mecca and taken my son Maghan hostage. Keep your eyes open, for you might see them.* Looks like I’ve done well to keep my eyes opened’, the Mamluk concluded. ‘Here is a

prince covered in gold, accompanied mostly by women. I suppose you are Hajji Maghan Keita, son of Hajji Musa Keita?'

'Well, I am, and…'

Maghan stumbled, but Inari's fiery side-look helped him refocus.

'And this message is… it is a forgery, made by… by bitter officials of Mecca who had been hoping for these slaves to be given to them, rather than being manumitted. But my good father fears Allah, and it is an act of piety to free slaves.'

Maghan's lie rested on the fact the Mamluk officials of Jeddah despised those of Mecca, who enjoyed better pay and prestige. This wasn't enough to convince the officer.

'Please dismount', he commanded, 'and ask your slaves to dismount too, for I don't speak their language.'

'My lord, you know this would anger my father. Imagine if he would inform the sultan of your misbehavior.'

'Good, then our good sultan will know I guarded Jeddah with diligence. Now please dismount.'

'My lord, you see that I am not tied. I am still carrying my gold, too. Do I look like a hostage to you?'

'Please dismount or I'll have to use force.'

The prince dismounted but didn't ask the others to do the same. Instead, he walked to the soldiers and handed them gold pebbles, explaining that his father wished that the good people of Jeddah also benefit from the generosity of the Malians. The Mamluk officer boomed in anger, but his voice was muffled by louder shouting from the many impatient pilgrims queueing at the gate. The soldiers grew nervous, and once one of them broke formation and accepted the gold, all did. Torn between his duty, the impatience of the pilgrims and the greed of his men, the officer finally accepted Maghan and his 'slaves' be admitted into the city under escort.

The port of Jeddah was quite a sight to behold. Here were ships coming from Egypt, Somalia, Zanj and India, with even one Chinese junk, all painting an unlikely fresco of colors. The Red Sea was glittering in the horizon. Maghan had never seen another sea than the Ocean off the coast of Mali and had genuinely believed the Red Sea was the color its name suggests. After seeing nothing but desert landscapes for months, he felt soothed by the blue horizon and fresh wind. As he and the escapees neared the wharves, holding their horse by the bridle, the heavy escort tightly surrounding them opened a gap at the front of their formation. A small black man dressed passed through and went to the prince with a big smile. He introduced himself as Rajab al-Murjabi, the most reputable merchant from Zanzibar. This reputation was self-proclaimed but, given how the soldiers had made way for him, Maghan judged he must have friends in high places. Rajab didn't wait for the prince to introduce himself back before inviting him for a drink in his cabin, nor did he wait for him to accept the invitation before turning around and striding towards his ship, one of the largest in the port. Maghan followed the merchant all the way to a luxurious cabin, with such fine carpets and cushions that only the slight pitching of the floor reminded him he was on a floating vessel. They sat across

one another, and a slave served them sweet-smelling tea. Finally having the occasion to speak, the prince thought appropriate to introduce himself.

‘I am Hajji Maghan Keita, son of—’

‘Son of Musa Keita, mansa of Mali, I know. When I saw you with your brocade and gold bracelets, leading a group of fine women under heavy escort, I guessed it could only be that famous Malian prince. Don’t you know you are the talk on everyone’s lips this morning? I’m honored to have you for tea. That’ll make all my friends jealous, I know. Now, please tell me, as I’m really curious: did you organize these slaves’ escape from Mecca, or did you join their cause after they took you hostage?’

Maghan spilled burning drops of tea on his fingers, and his face turned pale, which the Zanzibari merchant did not fail to notice. He showed his big smile again.

‘At your age, you make mistakes, and you learn, it’s normal. Your mistake was being so slow. I suppose you spent yesterday hiding in a cave to avoid being spotted in daylight. Yes? Ha, don’t you know that in the desert, news travel faster than wind? If you had gone straight to Jeddah, you’d perhaps have managed to fool some people. Maybe you’d even have fooled me! But even then, your plan would have failed. Were you planning to pretend like these slaves were yours to free, and ship them off without protection? That would have been their doom, trust me! For their sake, it’s best they return to their rightful owners. Once we finish our tea, I will tell the governor of Jeddah he can deport these slaves back to Mecca. Is the tea to your liking? You’ve never drank something like it, I know. The leaves come from China, with added spices from Ceylon.’

Maghan was staring at his reflection inside the teacup. His first instinct would have been to implore the man’s pity, but whatever pity a slave merchant might have been born with has long eroded away from buying and selling thousands of human beings. His second instinct was perhaps a smarter one. He took off his bracelets.

‘Accept these gifts’, he said, ‘and allow my friends to sail to Zanzibar under your protection. I will not forget your kindness and shall repay it twofold when the time comes. You have my word as a prince of Mali.’

‘Ha!’, the merchant laughed. ‘You look so young and inexperienced, yet you know how to bribe. I’m impressed – but I must refuse. Rajab al-Murjabi is the most reputable merchant in Zanzibar and accepts no bribes.’

‘Taking bribes is evil to you’, Maghan grumbled, ‘but selling slaves is not?’

‘I care about the well-being of slaves more than you do, Maghan Keita. You’d rather send them somewhere they don’t speak the language and don’t have any connections? I’d give them one month at most before they either die or fall right back into slavery. Also, I won’t accept your bribe because if your father learns that I helped his slaves escape, he’ll be quite furious. The Mali empire is Zanzibar’s main competitor on the African slave market, so any animosity between your father and I could be bad for business. You are old enough to understand such things, aren’t you?’

‘I shall become mansa after my father, though, so you don’t want any animosity with me either.’

‘Ha, that is true. So let me offer you an alternative. Instead of deporting the slaves back to Mecca, you can sell them to me.’

‘They are not for sale!’

‘I’ll buy them one pound of silver apiece. Silver is now more valuable than gold, so it’s a very good price, I assure you!’

‘They are not slaves anymore.’

‘Listen, Maghan Keita, I’m no expert in jurisprudence, but I know you don’t have the right to free slaves who belong to someone else. However, the law is slightly grayer when it comes to selling them, so long as you give the money to the owners afterwards. Therefore, if I was you, I’d take my generous deal. You care about those slaves, don’t you? Well, if they are deported back to Mecca, they’ll first be tortured, then slaughtered. If you sell them to me, on the other hand, they’ll stay alive and unharmed.’

The prince answered nothing, as if silence was a third option that could save his friends. Rajab promised him he’d spread the word that prince Maghan of Mali had been clever enough to sell the slaves who had taken him hostage. Maghan still said nothing as the Zanzibari man filled an ornate red silk purse with his friends’ price and handed it to him. The silver coins clanged like chains. Maghan bit his lips and accepted the deal. Inari had told him that she and the others would rather die than live as slaves, yet here he was saving their lives by selling them back into slavery. He had decided their fate for them. When he disembarked from the Zanzibari ship, his friends had already vanish to some dark hull. On the road back to Mecca, he wondered whether, inside that cabin, he could have made a good choice. If there was no good choice, was there any bad one? In the evening, when he arrived in Mecca, the lie Rajab had spread about his cleverness had preceded him – news indeed travel faster than wind in the desert – and his father hugged him very tight, calling him brave.

Chapter 7

The Malian caravan had been the most opulent in living memory when it arrived in Mecca, but it wasn’t anymore when it left. Barely enough gold was left for the road back to Mali; the prince’s capture had forced the Malians to linger in Mecca for a few more days, further depleting their resources. Yet morale was high, with the tale of Maghan’s capture on everyone’s lips. He was the hero and darling of the whole caravan. Maghan tried to ignore the stinging praises, riding apathetically at the head of the caravan. After a few days of marching, some men at the back of the caravan started claiming that a Mamluk cohort was right behind them. They swore to have seen mounted warriors on the horizon, but wherever they pointed to, others only saw rocky desert.

Somewhere in Northern Hedjaz, the caravan was caught in a fierce sandstorm. After the dust had settled, the rear half of the caravan, transporting most of the food and water supplies, and protected by the greater part of the soldiery, was out of sight. Musa ordered the marching to stop for a day to let the laggards catch up. That day came and went, but no one arrived. Musa’s counselors insisted that they turn back to Medina to resupply, but the Mansa’s deaf pride wouldn’t allow it. They kept onward, with rations cut in half. The half-rations became quarter-rations upon entering the Sinai, as it became clear the caravan would otherwise starve before reaching Egypt.

One afternoon, in the middle of the Sinai desert, raiders appeared on the horizon. The Malians, numbed by hunger and thirst, watched them approach like a man in agony visited by the Angel of Death. The few soldiers left to protect the caravan grabbed their spears but didn’t engage the foe,

knowing they were outnumbered. Instead, they gathered around the mansa and the prince, choosing to protect them over the others. That didn't deter the leader of the raiding band from riding directly towards Musa. When the soldiers pointed their spears at him, he minded them as much as lions showing their fangs from behind cage bars.

'O Hajji Musa Keita', the man said, 'I pray you will forgive us for looting your caravan.'

Maghan was staring at this man with more astonishment than fear. He had a majestic way of sitting on horseback, a well-groomed mustache and an elegant way to speak. He looked nothing like a mere bandit.

'You will understand', he went on, 'that we would much rather have avoided coming all the way from Lebanon. But our women and children are hungry. You have my word that we will use your gold only to feed them.'

Musa's throat was too dry to talk, so he took time to grab his gourd and drink precious few drops.

'Would you have me believe', the mansa finally said, 'that you are making a good deed by looting a caravan of pilgrims? Go away now, or you'll be sure to be sent straight to the flames of Hell!'

'We Druze believe souls are reincarnated. Perhaps what you call Hell is the world we already live in, with its wars and hatred and ignorance. But we must strive to make this world heavenly, even if it takes a thousand lifetimes.'

'When Allah throws you into hellfire, I wonder how long you'll keep refusing to believe it exists.'

'What God should do with my soul is not up to you. Now, if you would please—'

'When I arrive in Cairo, I'll tell the sultan about what you did. He'll hunt you down. You and your gang will get a taste of Mamluk swords.'

'Don't bother rousing Al-Nasir against us – he has already been persecuting us for years. He must have forgotten that the Druze have fought side-by-side with his father to kick the Crusaders out of the Holy Land. We have never rebelled against the Mamluks and never will. We are looting the sultan's friend today, but we won't take any of your food and water. We only need the gold. We won't harm you unless you resist. Now please order your men to drop their spears.'

'As if I would stoop so low as to yield to heretical scums. We'd rather all die as martyrs.'

'Wouldn't it be ironic for one named *Musa* (Moses in Arabic) to die in the Sinai while returning to Egypt? You have women and children with you, including your own son. Do you wish this arid desert to be watered with their blood? Now please order your kind to drop their weapons, dismount and unload all their valuables.'

Musa instead started yelling at his men to attack the infidel enemy. By dying as martyrs, he claimed, their reward in Heaven would be—The soldiers dropped their weapons in the sand and dismounted, too exhausted to fight. The rest of the caravan followed suit. Only the mansa remained on his saddle, frozen in sullen silence. Maghan had expected his father to turn red with rage, but instead, for the first time, he saw sadness in his eyes. After a moment, Musa finally dismounted and delivered his gold to the Druze raiders. The prince untied his most valuable belonging from his horse: the basin of Ibn al-Zayn. In truth, he was impatient to get rid of it. He had looted it, so it now felt like a fair retribution that it be looted from him. He unwrapped the basin and touched its elaborate surface for the first time since that fateful last day in Cairo. His subsequent prediction was

an unusual one: he witnessed his immediate future unfolding with every minute detail. He saw himself approaching the Druze chief, who was busy meticulously counting each gold nugget he dropped into a bag, and handing him the basin.

‘I want you not to destroy this basin but to sell it at its fair price’, he heard himself saying.

‘I’ll gladly grant you that wish’. The man smiled under his mustache and examined the piece with a sharp eye. ‘Oh, I recognize this signature – isn’t it Muhammad ibn al-Zayn? One of my cousins worked as his apprentice for two years in Damascus. I wasn’t aware he had moved to Cairo. I’m not surprised to find his signature on such a masterpiece. Be sure that I’ll sell it at its fair price.’

So the prediction went, and so Maghan went to fulfill it. He felt chills repeating what he had heard his future self say verbatim, wondering whether these words were truly his own, and whether free will could have enabled him to say something else. Once he had accomplished that short bit of destiny, he was surprised to see the Druze chief handing him the very bag he had just filled with gold.

‘Here is for you. You may accept it as payment for this beautiful piece.’

‘No, I… I can’t accept payment for it.’

‘You must. I made sure there is enough gold in this bag to sustain your caravan until it reaches Cairo. Once there, the sultan will surely pay back your generosity and provide you with the necessary resources to complete your journey back to Mali.”

‘Why… why giving it to me?’

The chief gestured Maghan to come closer.

‘Take a look at your father’, he whispered. ‘I think you’ll agree his pride has been sufficiently torn today. He would never have accepted me giving him back some of his own gold. I was hoping you would accept it for him.’

‘Thank you’, said Maghan taking the gold.

‘Don’t thank me. I’m only giving you back some of what I first took away from you.’

‘Well, yes, but you did not harm us though you could easily have slaughtered us all. Not only that, but you’re also making sure we won’t starve on our way to Cairo. Why?’

‘Why not? I’m here to save my people, not doom yours.’

Maghan returned to his horse and fastened the bag to it. His heart was racing. Neither own father nor sultan Al-Nasir, who ruled over great empires, had ever struck him with such awe as this humble leader of a persecuted community hidden in the Lebanese mountains. When the looting was done, and the Druze chief bid his farewells, Maghan noticed the man wasn’t carrying any of the booty on his own horse – except for the basin.

After the Druze party was gone, the caravan awaited an order from mansa Musa. He wouldn’t speak a word. A few excruciatingly long minutes in the scorching desert passed in silence, until prince Maghan Keita cleared his voice and shouted the order to resume the march. From that moment on, he was the leader of the caravan. He decided when to stop the march each evening, and when to resume it each morning. When coming across a town, he personally negotiated the purchase of

supplies. When the guides disagreed about which route to take next, they turned to him for a decision. Meanwhile, his father only sunk deeper into sullenness, his wet eyes staring at the sand below. One evening, after the caravan had stopped along Nile, the prince saw his father crouching alone by the riverside and feared to see him leap into the water to drown. He ran towards Musa but halted a few yards away from him, unsure what to say. How could he comfort a father who had only ever showed him anger and pride? As Maghan stood there hesitant, Musa briefly turned towards his son before staring back at the water. Maghan couldn't bear the awkward tension and returned to the camp, feeling cravenly.

A stinking, ghastly spectacle awaited the caravan as it neared Cairo. Severed head on pikes had been pegged along the road, grimacing at the travelers. Below each of them was an inscription, such as "I, Yehuda ben Moshe, have smuggled food for my own community, starving everyone else" or "I, John Psoter, have sold bread on the black market for a hundred times more than the fixed price". Most of these heads belonged to Jews and Copts, but some also to Arabs and even Mamluks. Maghan's stomach couldn't bear the sight of these heads, yet he carefully looked at each of them. Then his heart sank. He had found it: a skull beyond rotting with the inscription: "I, Muhammad ibn al-Zayn, have fomented sedition by spreading lies among the sultan's friends". Maghan started sweating, and the reins slipped out of his wet hands. Until now he had taken pride in leading the caravan, but he was now realizing the darker side of that responsibility. By going to Cairo, was he dooming everyone to come back to this road with their head on a pike? It wasn't hard for him to imagine the sultan gladly punishing the Malians for being the real cause of this crisis. Yet without going to Cairo and begging the sultan for supplies, how could they cross the Sahara back to their homeland? He wished he could pause the march and take time to think, but the stench and horror of these heads left no choice but to hurry forward, fast towards Cairo.

Chapter 8

Maghan was awakened by the muezzins calling for the dawn prayer but decided to stay in bed. What good was prayer anyway? He had not missed a single prayer since the start of his pilgrimage, believing that it was the right thing to do. Yet he'd also believed that visiting Muhammad ibn al-Zayn again was the right thing to do, that selling the runaway slaves was the right thing to do, that leading his caravan to Cairo was the right thing to do… Every time right had turned out worse than wrong. *Has Allah given men free will to allow them the excuse, after making the wrong choice, that they thought it was the right one?* He couldn't stop wondering.

He heard the clang of a key opening the lock of his room. Someone came it, but Maghan didn't bother leaving bed. It was only a servant coming to clean. The sultan had ordered Musa and his son to be assigned to separate rooms of the Citadel caravansary and prevented from leaving – for their own safety. What had become of the rest of the Malians, the prince didn't know. It had already been three days since he was locked inside this room. Was this how caliph Al-Mutakfi felt as well, having his life rest entirely in the palm of another man's hand? It was the sultan's decision whether to release him tomorrow, in a year, in a decade… Maghan twisted and turned, impatient for the servant to go away. Instead, the man drew closer to the bed. The prince hid completely under his sheets, but the servant still spoke to him.

‘O Hajji Maghan Keita, may I bring something to your attention? Someone left a crate under your window. This is dangerous. Rebels are roaming even the Citadel, and one of them could use this crate to—Well, please keep your window locked so long as it hasn’t been removed. This is for your safety.’

As soon as the man left, locking the door after him, Maghan leapt out of bed and ran to the window. Indeed, there was the crate below. The servant’s voice had had a pinch of irony. Why would someone leave a crate here, in the middle of a narrow back alley? He opened the window to look around – and he spotted a girl looking back at him with feline eyes at the corner of the alley. Her faced was blending beauty from distant lands, and she was around his age. After a moment she vanished behind the corner. Maghan kept staring in that direction, but she wouldn’t show herself again. Finally, he glanced back down at the crate and shivered. That ironic servant, that crate, that girl… Before his mind could catch up, he sat on the window frame, slid down to the crate, and felt an exhilarated thrill as he ran up the alley. Escaping the caravansary to follow that girl was surely not the right thing to do – therefore it was.

He found her around the corner, but she vanished again at the next one. He followed her so all the way to the back of the library. There, with cat-like movements, she climbed up buttresses and built-in ladders to the roof. After a much slower and clumsier climb, Maghan found himself upon a quiet piece of flat roof surrounded by walls on three sides, standing barely two yards away from her. He stood upright and puffed out his chest, half aware what kind of instinct that was.

‘It was brave of you to come with me, Maghan Keita’, she said. ‘I didn’t think you would. Thank you. My name is Nasirah. I’m the firstborn daughter of sultan Al-Nasir – but it doesn’t matter who I am. I have many more important things to tell you, so please sit. Don’t worry, no one will hear or see us from up here. Since I was little, this is the only place where I knew I could be left alone.’

As the prince hesitated to sit, the girl blushed and frowned.

‘You are the first boy I invite here, and I wouldn’t have done such a crazy thing unless I had a good reason. Do you understand?’

Nasirah didn’t notice Maghan was blushing just like her, because the red was camouflaged by his black skin. He sat awkwardly and started. How come he had never seen her last he was in Cairo, when he had met the sultan’s sons?

‘I am pleased to meet you, Nasirah’, he said with perhaps too much courtesy for the situation. ‘Have I already had the pleasure to meet you—Why are you smiling so?’

‘I’m sorry, it’s your way to speak Arabic. It’s so polite, it sounds like you are reading the Quran.’

‘Well, this is how I learned that language in Mali… Anyway, have I already had—’

‘You have not. When you last were in Cairo, I was in Alexandria with my mother and sisters. We go there every summer. But again, that really doesn’t matter for—Well actually, yes it does matter for what I want to tell you, because last year, when the great earthquake jarred Alexandria, I was there. You haven’t heard about it? It was terrible! It shook so hard, my sisters and I were sure we’d die. Then we heard a loud, ghastly noise – it was the lighthouse collapsing! I couldn’t believe it. After

thousands of years, it just happened to collapse during my lifetime[13]. That was no coincidence… What, you've never heard about the lighthouse of Alexandria? I wish you could have seen it before it fell into the sea. It was like the pyramids: very tall, and very old. That's why we all felt like it couldn't be a coincidence if it collapsed just last year. Outside Alexandria, there is a cave dwelled by a famous mystic. My mother went there to ask him if there was a reason for the collapse. Do you know what he told her? That a great tragedy was soon to befall the empire – and here we are a year later! The Mamluk empire is now on the brink of collapse. There's hunger and disease and persecution… That's why I needed to talk to you, Maghan Keita. You can help save the empire.'

Maghan looked away from her electric gaze. He wished he was the brave prince she expected, but knew he wasn't.

'I'll tell you what you need to do. But first, you need to understand what is happening, and why it is happening. Will you listen to me?' Nasirah took a gold dinar coin out of her pocket. 'Look here: they still call it a "gold dinar", but see? It's not gold at all! It's iron and copper. People aren't stupid, they know that money has become worthless, but my father keeps denying the truth, because he knows the moment he admits it, he might lose his throne. To keep his monster of a lie alive, my father needs to feed it with the blood of innocents. Just last week he had one of my closest confidants whipped because she was caught buying food off the black market. She'd always been such a gentle, frail girl, and she died from her wounds soon after. Her name was Marya Psoter. The same day she passed, her father was beheaded, also because he had used the black market to survive. Maybe you've seen his head along the road when you came…"

Nasirah paused to let her anger cool down, in vain.

'I hate my father! I truly hate him! There would be no black markets if he hadn't fixed the price of staples. There would be no restless minting if we had just waited for the gold crisis to die down. He surely thinks I'm too stupid to understand that, as a young girl. He keeps buying me fancy dresses and jewels, expecting me to squeak with joy, as if I didn't know people are dying.'

'Why don't you just tell him all this?'

'Do you want to know what happens when I tell my father anything serious? Either he laughs it off or pretends he didn't hear anything. And I'm being lucky. When my mother says something that he doesn't like, he turns red with rage and beats her.'

'Why won't his advisers talk to him, then?'

'My father surrounds himself with two kinds of advisers. The first are scholars and savants, to make him appear like a wise, enlightened ruler, but do you know what he calls them in private? *Paper-gnawing rats*! The second are his Mamluks comrades, but these brutes are too loyal to say anything against him. There is only one man in Cairo who can talk to the sultan as his equal, and you know who I'm talking about. Do you understand, then, what I'm asking from you?'

'My father is being held captive like me. Why would the sultan listen to the man he humiliated?'

'He will free you soon. Do you think he can keep holding a foreign ruler captive, and not face any diplomatic consequences? Nobody will believe his excuse that it's just for your protection. In a few

13 The lighthouse of Alexandria had already been heavily damaged by past earthquakes, but the one of 1323 was its coup de grace. Although we associate that famous lighthouse with Antiquity, it kept standing almost to the end of the Middle-Ages. Is it truly a coincidence that in 1324, just one year after Egypt lost one of its two wonders of the Ancient World, the caravan of mansa Musa arrived?

days, I'm sure my father will kindly take a cup of tea with yours, as if nothing happened; then he'll deport your caravan out of Egypt under heavy escort. He's impatient to get rid of you. But before you leave, your father must tell mine the truth, from one ruler of a great empire to another. Will you ask this to him?'

'How could I tell him? We're kept in two separate room.'

'Remember the servant who told you about the crate under your window? He's also cleaning your father's room. So next time, give him this.' Nasirah drew a sheet of paper from her sleeve. It was so tightly folded the corners were skin-bruising sharp. 'When you unfold it, you'll see there is blank space left at the bottom. I know you have writing material in your room. We could have brought this letter to your father directly, but words of a stranger won't sway him, unless accompanied with those of his son. You've seen the devastation Cairo has fallen into, haven't you? I heard Baybars boasting about how he arrested Muhammad ibn al-Zayn, after he spoke the truth to you. Write down everything that brave man told you.'

'Did… you know Muhammad ibn al-Zayn?'

'I've never met him, but I've had a flowerpot with his signature in my room for years – a gift from my father, that shameless hypocrite! But that doesn't matter. You can write, can't you? Then please avenge the innocents' blood with ink!'

'The rest of the letter… did you write it yourself?'

'Others did. Brave men I won't name. Did you think I am acting alone? Half the court is behind us!'

Maghan felt relieved to hear they were not alone. He stretched his hand to take the paper, but instead of giving it to him, Nasirah took a piece of cloth, a needle and a thread, and started sewing a patch somewhere on his clothes with the swiftness of a princess raised in the womanly arts, safely hiding the paper under it.

'There, it is better to carry it like this', she explained, 'so that if you come across a patrol on your way back and they search you, they won't think to look under that patch.'

'Wait—'

Maghan had wanted to touch the letter to predict whether their plan was going to succeed, but now it was too late.

'Now you must go back to the caravansary', she said. 'Your absence risks being noticed with each passing minute, and some well-meaning servant might remove the crate from below your window. I'll stay here a while longer, so they won't know we were together. May Allah guide your steps, Maghan Keita! Now go!'

Maghan nodded and started climbing down. He hurried back up. A Mamluk patrol was passing down below. Once it was gone, the prince's courage had lost its inertia. He turned back to Nasirah with a bad feeling creeping through his mind. Something seemed wrong with her plan.

'You can go now', Nasirah insisted. 'Don't worry, patrols never follow one another closely, so the next one might not pass here before a while.'

'But wait, Nasirah, you said your father might lose his throne if the truth comes out. If he falls, and a rival Mamluk faction takes over, I'm worried you might get slaughtered – or worse!'

The princess blushed, took Maghan's hands in her own and squeezed them.

'It's so noble of you to worry about me, Maghan, but thousands are dying as we speak. We must save them first.'

'But… Well…'

'Go!'

Nasirah let go of his hands. With a silent goodbye, Maghan went, jumped off the buttresses and ran to the caravansary, stopping at each alley corner to make sure the way was clear. His heart was racing in his chest, but it wasn't stress. For a moment, he forgot about the patrols and the fate of the Mamluk empire. He saw himself a few years from now, returning to Cairo, seeing Nasirah again, getting to know her better—his heart stopped. He had reached the caravansary, and the crate was still under his window – with Baybars sitting on it.

Chapter 9

Baybars stood up, stepped on the crate and stretched out his hand to the freezing boy.

'Come on now, I'll help you climb back', he said. 'After all, this was the way you came out, I presume?'

He waited a few seconds, but the prince wouldn't move an inch towards his generously stretched hand. Since Maghan had rejected his phony display of courtesy, Baybars felt morally justified to grab him by the collar and lift him to the room like a basket of groceries. Four lower-ranking Mamluks were waiting inside. Baybars ordered them to search the prince thoroughly and strip him of all his clothes if necessary. Maghan would have preferred his naked body being examined by four brutes if that meant they'd never find the letter, but they noticed the patch almost immediately. Baybars sat down on a chair, unfolded the letter and read it with a frowning smile.

'Interesting, oh, interesting!', he blurted. 'Who gave it to you?'

Maghan did not answer. Baybars had not expected him to.

'Don't be so shy! I want to know who wrote this, because I want to know who deserves my respect. As a warrior, you know, bravery is the one quality I admire the most. And the person who wrote this, oh! Writing a single line on that sheet would cost someone their life, but they wrote a hundred! That's the equivalent of charging alone on a whole army. Stupid, insane, suicidal, but brave. We Mamluks show mercy to the brave.'

Once more, Baybars paused to savor Maghan's terrified silence.

'You know, my dear Maghan Keita, we'll eventually find whoever gave you this letter even if you don't name him – or her. In fact, I can already guess it was a woman, given how well that patch was sewed. I know you wouldn't be able to sew two stitched before you puncture your fingers with the needle. If you give us enough time, we'll trace back where the cloth and thread came from; we'll compare the letter's handwriting to every document in our archives; we'll find the servant who placed that crate under this window and torture him… We're sure to find the culprit eventually – but you can spare us the trouble. Just tell us who she is.'

Baybars stood up, and he and his four subordinates closed on the small prince like the five fingers of a titanic hand. Maghan braced. He thought of Nasirah and those brave souls who had risked their lives getting that letter to him. He had failed them, but he wouldn't betray them. One word from him, and he'd be planting the heads of half the court along the road to Cairo. Now more than ever, he knew what the right decision was.

'No one gave me this letter', he answered. 'Because I am the one who wrote it. I sewed a patch around it and asked a servant to leave a crate below my window so I could go find some official to give it to.'

'Then why did you run back here with the letter still on you?'

'Because a patrol was blocking my way, so I decided to retreat and try again later.'

'Do you truly expect us to believe that?'

'By Allah, I am telling the truth.'

Maghan had chills lying in the name of Allah, but implicating Nasirah and the others would surely have been a graver sin. Baybars laughed. Suddenly it occurred to the prince that he didn't have any sewing material in his room and that his handwriting was an undecipherable scrawl – yet Baybars didn't press him on any of these incoherencies. Maghan could only guess that the Mamluks would rather incriminate him, a foreigner, than half the court and the sultan's own daughter.

'Maghan Keita', Baybars concluded, 'you just confessed to attempting to spark a rebellion against our beloved sultan, despite being under his protection and hospitality. You are under arrest. Come with us.'

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Outside, the Egyptian sun could very well have been shining bright and hot, but down here it didn't matter at all. Maghan couldn't stop shivering. His Malian clothes had not been cut out for the damp cold of a dungeon. His throat and lungs felt like they were scorched by thorny icicles. The sound of his own breathing was ghastly, but at least it was preferable to the stone, maddening silence he'd have to suffer otherwise. His only measure of time passing was the arrival of meals, which he forced himself to swallow painfully through his burning throat. The worst ordeal was waiting without knowing what and for how long. Shortly after his arrest, he'd been asked to sign his confession, but since then they seemed to have forgotten about him. He tried touching the door to predict when it would open next, but so much future suffering unfolded he huddled to the very back of the cell. Perhaps being forgotten here forever was his punishment, and there was nothing more to expect. He began wishing he could be executed instead of dying slowly in the mold and cold… The heavy metallic lock clanged. Two Mamluks lifted him by the arms and dragged him to another cell. This one was inside the thick walls of the Citadel. It was much warmer, with a proper bed and two arrow slits hinting of sunlight. Doctors soon came to treat the damage caused by the previous cell. No one told the prince why he suddenly enjoyed better treatment. He began to fear Nasirah had been caught and forced to confess, thus disproving his own confession. A restless day passed, and then a sleepless night. As morning light started shining timidly through the arrow slits, he was taken

out of this cell, bathed and dressed in his most opulent Malian costume. Then Baybars and his men came, made sure his wrists were properly cuffed, and took him to the entrance of the Great Iwan.

Chapter 10

Under the great green dome and red pillars, the floor was packed with the whole court, dressed in their richest clothes. The colorful crowd parted on either side as Baybars led the cuffed prince forward. Though all were festively clad, the mood was nothing but. These fancy ministers and ambassadors and magistrates hissed the Malian boy passing by them. Maghan kept his head high. At least, he thought, Nasirah and the others weren't walking this trail of shame with him. As he neared the throne, he saw the sultan's many sons – all spoiled brats. One of them, the seventh son, had a trained pigeon fly straight at the prince's face before retreating to his shoulder, which made him laugh hysterically[14]. As he was composing himself after this avian attack, Maghan noticed the sultan's wives, concubines and daughters were also here, and he anxiously started looking for Nasirah—There she was! Their eyes met. She smirked. A tough hand jerked him forward, and he had to keep on walking forward, burying a thousand conflicting feelings inside him. Now, the most elite Mamluks parted near the throne. There were in fact two thrones side-by-side: one for sultan Al-Nasir and one, larger and more luxurious, for the caliph. It took the prince a moment to notice that his father was standing beside him, looking down with surrendering eyes. The sultan had the Sword of the Coin on his belt, taken back from Musa. Suddenly the room went silent, as caliph Al-Mustakfi stood up from his throne. Maghan knew there was no use looking up at him with pleading eyes. Whatever bond of friendship had united them around the books in the library was worth nothing in this throne room.

'Now the ceremony shall commence. I, caliph Al-Mustakfi of the House of Abbas, commander of the believers and successor to the Prophet – peace be upon him – am hereby confirming Mamluk sultan Al-Nasir, son of Qalawun the Thousander, as the rightful lord of all the lands of Mali; Musa Keita shall surrender his title of mansa to the sultan, and henceforth serve as his vassal to administer Mali on his behalf. This decree comes as a rightful and merciful punishment to Musa Keita and his son Maghan Keita, guilty of betraying their generous host. They have attempted to challenge his position, so now they shall lose theirs. May Allah the Almighty bless the glorious rule of the Mamluks!'

The sultan smiled, the crowd cheered, but Al-Mustakfi remained expressionless, like a wooden puppet.

'Now, to seal the yielding of Mali as a province to the Mamluk sultanate', the caliph continued, 'I demand that Musa Keita, as well as his son and heir Maghan Keita, bow before their suzerain, sultan Al-Nasir'.

Maghan clenched his teeth and held his breath, waiting to see what his father would do. Musa knelt, then bowed until his forehead touched the floor. The prince mumbled. The father he knew would never have even lowered his eyes to another man. This felt like a nightmare. Was it indeed a nightmare? He started at Baybars' voice.

'Maghan Keita, you must bow as well, to redeem your treason'.

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14 Al-Muzaffar would eventually become sultan, but his obsession with pigeon racing and his extravagance would earn him the scorn of the Mamluk elite, who assassinated him thirteen months into his reign.

He answered nothing, shivering in fear and confusion. The sultan gestured Baybars to draw his sword. It unsheathed with a dreadful grind.

‘The sultan is most merciful’, Baybars said. ‘You should have been executed for treason, but our beloved sultan chose to spare your life if you submit to him. Do not make him regret his mercy. Bow down now and live.’

Musa grunted something unintelligible from the floor. He was ignored.

‘I won’t repeat myself’, Al-Nasir said. ‘Bow down to me or die.’

‘No.’

‘No?’

Maghan had said no without previous thought, but for once he was glad his heart had spoken out loud, when he was about to yield. Now, he had found the strength to keep standing, and there was no turning back.

‘No’, he repeated, louder.

The sultan laughed, which gave the whole crowd license to laugh along with him. Then he stood up, the caliph sat down, and everyone hushed.

‘Do you believe you’re being brave? Let me remind you – nay, let me remind everyone here – how you fled before a small crowd of bums in the streets of Cairo, like the whiny little craven you are!’

The court forced itself to laugh anew. Maghan bit his lips. He was about to defend his pride but paused. He would sound pathetic if he did. Instead, he took time to breathe and gathered his courage.

‘Why do…’

He stumbled. He needed a lot more courage. He filled his lungs with a hard, deep breath.

‘Why do you care so much that a whiny little craven bows before you? Aren’t you the first among the world’s greatest warriors? You are desperate to see me bow, because otherwise you won’t rule legitimately over an inch of Mali. As my father gave up his title, I am now taking his succession as mansa Maghan. If my people know their mansa resisted, that will give them courage to resist as well.’

‘You do have some brains, boy – but no eyes and no ears. Don’t you see your father is bowing to *me*? Didn’t you hear he’s giving his title over to *me*?’

‘The constitution of Mali[15] is clear on the matter: “The Keita family is the reigning family upon the empire.” I am a Keita. You are not.’

‘The constitution of Mali, eh? As a Muslim, the only constitution I need is the Holy Quran, and I follow the decrees from our beloved caliph, the successor to the Prophet – peace be upon him. You, on the other hand, are appealing to rules written by your savage, heathen ancestors, who worshiped malformed idols carved from wood.’

‘My ancestors were Muslims since the birth of Islam! We are descended from Bilal Keita, appointed by the Prophet as the first muezzin.’

15 The constitution of the Mali empire, written in the 1220s, is a fascinating document. Most notably, it respects the right to life and women’s rights.

‘Does anyone here believe this nonsense?’, Al-Nasir asked the crowd.

Of course, no one said yes. With malicious pleasure, the sultan turned to the caliph and asked him to confirm that the first muezzin of Islam, Bilal ibn Rabah, was never named Keita and had no connection with Mali. Al-Mustakfi acquiesced, and the court sneered. Maghan looked down, knowing he had made a mistake falling for the sultan’s provocation over his ancestry.

‘See?’, the sultan concluded, ‘your pride is standing on a lie. You, the dynasts, fabricate fantasy lineages to justify why you should rule despite having no personal merit. Do you think being born is an achievement worthy of a crown? Then let me remind you that every single man on this earth, down to the lowest beggar, was also born. Yet somehow, for all of History, undeserving men have ruled their betters by virtue of being born. But now, the times are changing. A few decades ago, here in Cairo, the Mamluks have overthrown their fat masters. For the first time, the fittest ruled instead of well-born weaklings. The *Age of the Mamluks* had begun. And not only here: in India as well, the Mamluks have risen to power[16]. I’ve heard they even had a woman as sultan[17] – because even a female Mamluk is worthier than a male dynast. Egypt, Syria, Arabia and India have been freed from the tyranny of the unworthy – but we won’t stop there! The spark of justice is lit, and now it is our duty to spread it to the rest of the world. Today, we’re starting with Mali; once we gain access to their limitless supply of gold and slaves, nothing will stop us from liberating the petty sultanates of the Maghreb; then, starting in Spain, we’ll take and convert the infidel kingdoms of Europe… Soon the whole world will be ruled its best men. So now, Maghan Keita, let me ask you: how long do you think Mali could withstand an invasion from the world’s finest warriors? Even if you refuse to yield, I’ll conquer your land as easily as cutting through butter. As easily as cutting through your neck. Your death will have been as futile as your short life. Baybars, please proceed.’

‘Spare his life!’, Musa screamed, jumping to his feet. ‘He’s just a boy, too young to know what he is doing.’

‘Your son’s age is no excuse. Allah gave him free will, like everyone else.’

Two Mamluks seized the prince with their thick hands and forced him to bend his neck. Baybars stroke a few blows in the empty, to warm up his arm.

‘*Free will is the freedom to do bad when we can do good, but also the freedom to do good when we can do bad*.’

Maghan had spoken in the most pristine Arabic he could muster, as if quoting from the Quran itself. He had intended these to be his last words, but the cutting blow didn’t come. Instead, he gave Baybars pause.

‘Baybars’, the sultan insisted impatiently, ‘why isn’t his head rolling already? That boy did bad when he could do good, not the other way around.’

‘Only Allah knows that’, Maghan said.

Silence fell on the Great Iwan. Behind him, Maghan could hear the crowd whispering among themselves. He seized his chance.

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16 The lesser-known Mamluk sultanate of Delhi, ruling over much of Northern India, lasted from 1206 to 1290.

17 On his deathbed, the Mamluk sultan of Delhi Iltutmish appointed his daughter Razia has his successor, considering her worthier than any of his sons. After four years of being the first and only female Mamluk sultan, Razia was deposed and was later killed while attempting to retake the throne.

‘Spilling my blood won’t feed the thousands of souls starving in the streets of Cairo and around Egypt. You are letting them starve. It takes a thousand dinars to buy a piece of bread!’

‘Just die already!'

The sultan drew the Sword of the Coin, rose the blade and stroke down. There rang a metallic clang, immediately followed by the rasp of a hundred swords unsheathing. Then silence. No one moved. After a long, long moment, the still living prince finally dared looking up. Baybars stood near Al-Nasir, his sharp blade pressed against the sultan’s neck. All around them, the other Mamluks were raising their swords towards Baybars, ready to strike him down if he dared to move any further.

‘Baybars…’, whispered Al-Nasir as a few drops of blood came trickling down to his collar. ‘Have you lost your mind? Has a jinn taken hold of you? Now, come back to your senses and put down that sword.’

‘I haven’t lost my senses, no. That’s why I won’t obey you.’

‘Have you forgotten who I am?’

‘No, but apparently you have. Look what happened to your precious Sword of the Coin, there…’

He nodded to the spot on the floor where the blade had shattered to pieces. The knob coin had vanished. The sultan growled.

‘You’ll pay for this. Dearly.’

‘I’ll pay only a piece of bread, then. After all, your father was bought for a thousand dinars, and this boy spoke true when he said that’s now worth a piece of bread. Thus, I speak for of all Mamluks when I say you’ve reduced our value to damn crumbs! You’ve made a thousand dinars worthless, but I was bought for six hundred; Qutuz here cost five hundred; Tughra, five hundred and fifty; Tumanbay, four hundred and seventy-five; Aybak, five hundred…’

Baybars kept on pricing every single Mamluk warrior in the room. Each one lowered his sword upon being mentioned, feeling Baybars was speaking for them. Al-Nasir thought fast. This was a delicate situation, but not the worst he had had to face over his many years as sultan.

‘My brothers!’, he boomed in a confident voice. ‘I’ve known every one of you since we were slaves. For years at my side, you’ve all become stronger, wiser, and more loyal. Your value is beyond questioning, and beyond any finite sum of dinars. Yet I agree that our worth has been diminished, not as individual warriors, but as a group. Our enemies know that because we are invincible warriors, the sole way to defeat us is to turn us against each other. Those sneaky Malians came close to achieving their goal today. With the help of the Copts, the Druze and the Jews, they’ve almost managed sow division in our rank and destroy our esprit de corps. They think they can bring down our glorious reign of justice and merit. Ha! Are we going to fall so easily into their trap, or are we going to stand together as Mamluk brothers?’

At this, the ‘brothers’ threw roaring acclamations to their sultan. A hundred swords pointed back towards Baybars as favor swung away from him. Yet he did not flinch. His blade kept threatening the sultan’s neck, until the cheers died out and there was tense silence again.

‘You speak lots of words, Al-Nasir’, Baybars finally said, ‘like you mint lots of coins. You’ve made the coins worthless, so why should your words have any value?’

Some Mamluks laughed, but the others hissed. Maghan heard no sound behind him. The whole assistance had had the good sense to run away at the first sign of the upcoming storm of swords. The half-deserted Great Iwan was now eerily quiet, and all Maghan could hear was the deafening sound of his own heartbeat. This time, he thought, no one would come to save him. There was a sudden, general start, but no one struck a blow. Someone had stood up.

‘This is unacceptable!’, the caliph exclaimed with the tone of an amateur actor trying to play a leading role with stage fright. ‘Al-Nasir, you have failed your duties as sultan. I cannot stand to see a Muslim lord letting his own people starve – fellow Muslims – and blaming them for their woe! I am hereby stripping you of you title of sultan and… and naming you governor of Aleppo. Consequently, the good Mamluk Baybars, who has proven beyond doubt his valor on the battlefield, his faith in Allah and his care for the people, shall become the new sultan – taking effect immediately.’

‘Silence, you fat bookworm!’, Al-Nasir shouted. ‘Stay in your place, or I’ll lock you up in a cell where you won’t see sunlight or books ever again.’

‘How dare you insult and threaten our beloved caliph?’, Baybars retorted. ‘This is blasphemy!’

Al-Nasir answered, but his voice was drowned in acclamation for Baybars from every Mamluk present. He bowed his head, accepting defeat. Maghan saw caliph Al-Mustakfi smiling to him as he sat back down on his lavish throne. But the prince felt no relief. In a moment, he feared, Baybars would turn to his father and to him, and ask them to submit as vassals. Instinctively, he looked to his father and gasped in astonishment. Musa was standing upright, his chin proudly forward, looking like the mansa he had always been. With a majestic gait, mansa Musa walked to Baybars, approaching him so closely the new sultan was compelled to take a step back before him.

‘It is an honor, O Baybars’, Musa declared, ‘to be the first Muslim sovereign to congratulate you for becoming sultan. May your reign be long and glorious, and may you forever count me as a friend, and Mali as your ally. To Allah the most merciful, I pray our empires will keep prospering alongside one another in brotherhood, as they always have been.’

A spontaneous tear fell down Maghan’s cheek. He understood that his father had just saved their lives and Mali’s freedom.

Maghan and Musa spent the night in the Striped Palace, as honored guest once again. The next day at noon, they were informed the sultan wished to see them privately in his quarters. They found Baybars sitting on a loggia overlooking the city. On the table beside him, blocks of salt were stacked into a small pyramid.

‘Please sit down’, Baybars told them. ‘Like in your Mali, now here as well’ – he gestured towards the breathtaking view on Cairo – ‘salt has become more precious than gold. Ironic, isn’t it? When you first arrived, we had wished for you to feel at home in Cairo, but now Egypt has indeed become just like your home. Therefore, please accept this salt as my present to you. Once you decide to return home – although you are welcome to stay here for as long as you want – your caravan will be loaded with enough salt, water and food you need to cross the Sahara back to Timbuktu.’

Musa thanked Baybars for his generosity and politely insisted that he wouldn’t abuse his hospitality. The Malians were to leave in the morrow at dawn. Then he put his hand on his son’s shoulder and

squeezed it a little. He had told Maghan, before they came, that he must thank Baybars for saving his life. The prince obliged halfheartedly.

‘It is rather I who should thank you, Maghan Keita’, Baybars answered. ‘What you said about free will also being the freedom to do good – that compelled me to act. For my whole life, as a slave and then as a warrior, I simply obeyed. I never questioned an order; no matter if it was good or evil, I believed that following orders can never be wrong, because loyalty is always good. But yesterday, you made me realize that if I kept following orders, I’d share responsibility for the collapse of sultanate.’

‘Now that you are sultan’, Musa asked, ‘what will you do to fix this crisis?’

‘Nothing. Whatever I could do would only make it worse. I don’t remember which sage said: if you want water to stop being murky, don’t dip your hand in it.’

‘If you may listen to a man who ruled Mali for twelve years, O Baybars, I assure you that even when you do nothing, the people will blame you for any evil that happens to them.’

‘Then it is good that I am not their ruler, in name at least. The caliph is their ruler, and he is the successor to the Prophet. Blaming him is blasphemy.’

Maghan bit his lip. The caliph, his friend, had been locked back into his golden cage… No matter that Baybars had saved his life, Maghan already regretted thanking him. All these gruesome days in the desert spent anticipating what he’d say to that violent brute, and now he was thanking him! The question came out of him.

‘Do you remember Muhammad ibn al-Zayn?’

‘Why, yes, of course.’

‘He had a wife and a daughter. And… And…’

The prince mumbled. He wanted to throw so many reproaches and insults at him but knew that he shouldn’t. The relief from expressing what he held in his heart was not worth putting him, his father and his whole people in danger.

‘Don’t worry about them’, Baybars said casually, ‘I took them into my service.’

Maghan lowered his eyes, not wanting to know what kind of service that was. The sultan stood up, signifying an end to their meeting.

‘Farewell, O Hajji Musa Keita, O Hajji Maghan Keita. Before you leave, let me say one last thing. When you first came to Cairo, you brought gold. Now, you brought wisdom. This taught me that there can be too much gold, but never too much wisdom. Thus, next time you come, please bring one more than the other!’

Chapter 11

Maghan and Musa were riding side by side at the head of the caravan. At their back, the Cairo skyline was glimmering under the rising sun. Instead of cutting through the bare and empty Sahara as it had arrived in Egypt, the caravan was to travel through the various small sultanates of the Maghreb and, once in Morocco, turn South towards Mali. The queen of cities had already faded beyond the horizon, when Musa spoke to his son.

‘Do you know why I decided to bring you along with me on this pilgrimage, Maghan? It was to determine whether you have the mettle to become mansa after me. I had serious doubts before we left Mali. And now, to speak truthfully, I am still unsure I should name you as my heir. I think my brother Suleiman would make a better mansa.’

‘Why… What! I am the one who refused to bow down! The sultan wanted to cut my head, and I still didn’t yield! I saved Mali’s honor, I was brave, I… I…’

Maghan paused, realizing that he was raising his voice against his father for the first time.

‘I led the caravan out of the Sinai myself’, he went on with more self-control. ‘Haven’t I proven to be strong enough for you?’

‘You say you were strong, but an ape is strong too. Does that, in your opinion, make an ape worthy to rule?’

‘Was I an ape?’

‘Oh yes, you were! In the foolishness of your youth, you were ready to play the martyrs… Did you want your father to see you die before his eyes?’

‘I saved the honor of Mali.’

‘Spare me the noble intentions. You truly have no political acumen, though to be fair to you, neither did Al-Nasir. He thought reducing me to his vassal would make him the greatest ruler in the world – but I knew it would rather mean his downfall. If Mali had become his province, with myself as his vassal, I would have sent him so much gold and slaves as tribute that the Mamluk economy would have crumbled overnight; at the snap of a finger, I’d have collapsed his empire and thus, made Mali free once more. That’s why I bowed to him. Do you understand now, what it takes to be a good ruler?’

‘Still, I wouldn’t have bowed. It just felt wrong.’

‘Still listening to your ungodly intuition, are you?’ Musa sighed and, after a pause, slowly asked: ‘Did I ever tell you how I came to power?’

‘Why, of course. Grandfather disappeared in the Sahara on his way to the pilgrimage.’

‘Then I lied to you. I probably thought you’d try something stupid if you knew the truth, but now that you almost got yourself killed anyway, I’ll tell you what really happened. You grandfather never set out to Mecca. No, instead, he went to the opposite direction – across the Ocean. He claimed that, on the other side, there was a new continent. No one had ever seen this continent, and it is never mentioned in the Quran, but he insisted it was real, so he set sail with two thousand ships. Only one ship ever came back, and her sailors said the rest of the fleet had been carried westward by a current so strong it would be impossible to sail back[18].’

Musa frowned when he saw that his revelation had lit a spark of awe in his son’s eyes. He hurried to extinguish it.

‘Do you think he did something admirable? He abandoned his entire people in the pursuit of an illusion. And far too often, you remind me of him, Maghan. Your grandfather talked about doing

18 Yes, this is a true story. What became of the Malians who sailed to the New World? Their fate is still unknown but perhaps one day, someone will unearth medieval African artefacts on the coast of Brazil…

what he felt was right, just like you – and I never saw him again. Don't you know what all insane people have in common? They listen to themselves.'

'You say listening to oneself is insanity but wouldn't listening only to others be naivety.'

Musa chuckled. 'I've asked myself this very question after watching your father disappeared beyond the waves. In my grief and anger, I also started questioning – Allah forgive me – what our Creator is for, if He's just sitting up there letting every kind of injustice happen. Then I understood: we humans are all flawed sinners; we cannot listen to ourselves, lest we become selfish lunatics; neither can we listen to our peers, because they too are wicked and ignorant; therefore, we need a higher entity to tell us right from wrong beyond doubt. Allah has given us an absolute compass, so we don't need to fret over who is right or wrong. For that, I praise Him with all my soul.'

Maghan did not answer. He disagreed with his father but was unsure why. In the Citadel library, he had read Aristotle and had been puzzled at his concept of *reason*. At the time he hadn't grasped what it was for, but now he wondered whether using one's reason was a better alternative than trusting a higher entity to decide what is right. When he had been relying on his intuition to make decisions, was it reason or faith? Was intuition some divine whisper, or a kind of reasoning that can't yet be put to words?

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When the first oasis town on their route came within sight, the Malians cheered, impatient to rest and enjoy the urban pleasures. But the town's doors only opened long enough to let soldiers sally out, with a mission to block the caravan from approaching any further. The townsfolk were terrified to meet the same fate as Cairo. Every Malian, even Musa and Maghan, were barred from entering; their camp had to be laid a safe distance from the walls – as if gold was a contagious disease. The next town offered them much the same welcome, and the next. The caravan soon reached the Mediterranean coast, and Musa was confident that Tunis would open its gates. It did not. At least the Tunisians supplied them with food and water for free, too afraid to bring home any cursed Malian gold.

One evening, as they were nearing Morocco, the Malians came across a pilgrim caravan from Tangier. Both caravans camped for the night at the same spot, and the Malians and Moroccans mingled in each other's camps. While Musa chatted gravely with Tangerian officials, Maghan saw a young man who, though older than him by a few years, was close enough in age for the prince to confidently go and salaam him.

'Peace be upon you, brother. My name is Hajji Maghan Keita.'

'Oh, are you the son of mansa Musa?'

'You know my father?'

'Who doesn't? He's made enough of a mess in Egypt that his name echoed all the way to Tangier. I hope that, by the time I reach Cairo, the city won't be in shambles anymore.'

‘And who are you?’

‘Oh sorry, I forgot to introduce myself. My name is Ibn Battuta. I am studying to be a judge. This pilgrimage is just the beginning. After Mecca, I want to travel to the best learning centers and become the best judge in the world—Oh, is that your father over there?’

‘Why, yes.’

‘He looks just like I imagined him. But he seems miserable. Did something happen?’

‘It’s been weeks since we haven’t seen the inside of a city. Everyone turns us away like we’re leppers. I’m sure those officials from your city just told my father he won’t be welcomed in Morocco either.’

‘I’m not surprised.’

‘You are studying law, are you not? Can’t you find some loophole that would force Tangier to open its gate to us?’

‘I didn’t become a judge to turn myself into the most hated man in my hometown’, Ibn Battuta said with a smile.

‘Then, why did you become a judge?’

‘You’ve just asked for my help as a judge, didn’t you? Well, there you have my reason. Who doesn’t need a judge? Allah has spread humans all over the world and, humans being humans, they always have disputes. Therefore, as a judge, I’ll be able to travel anywhere from Tangier to Guangzhou and be sure never to be out of work! It is the perfect job to explore the world!’

Maghan bit his lip. He had just made a sad realization.

‘You are quite lucky’, the prince grumbled.

‘Why, I never thought a prince would call lucky the common man I am!’

‘Well, I’ve just realized that if I am to rule Mali one day, I’ll have to stay in Mali. Even if I do another pilgrimage, I’ll go no further than Mecca. I’ll never see India or Ceylon or China. You, on the other hand, are free to travel the world as you please. I’d gladly give up the throne of Mali to have your freedom, but… I can’t abandon my people.’

‘You know, if I want to travel, perhaps it is because I cannot bear any more responsibility than my own little person. You, meanwhile, are ready to carry the weight of an empire on your shoulders. I’ll be a mere passenger through History, while you’ll be the one making it. Which one of us two has chosen the best way to live?’

‘I hope you that in a few years, you’ll come to Mali. We’ll see, then, which one of us two is the happiest.’

Maghan Keita and Ibn Battuta kept on chatting through the night. As morning dawned, the two overnight friends said farewell. Mansa Musa waited until the Moroccan caravan had disappeared beyond the eastern horizon, then ordered his own caravan to turn southward. He would not come to Morocco to be humiliated again when they’d deny him entry into its cities. His counselors objected that, from here, crossing the Sahara from North to South would take the longest time, but the mansa did not listen.

Chapter 12

After weeks across the bare desert, the caravan reached the northernmost town of the Mali empire, but no one rejoiced. Taghaza looked even more barren and desolate than the brown, flat waste where it stood. Maghan had heard about that infamous salt-mining town, but this was beyond anything he could have pictured. On its outskirts, they were greeted by the grins of dead slaves dumped in trenches. The prince was tempted to beg his father not to stop here and keep going and going as far away from this place as possible, but he knew the caravan's salt supplies were running low. Taghaza was the only place where they could resupply on the way to Timbuktu. When Musa and Maghan entered the town, they noticed that a merchant caravan had arrived a short while before them; its camels were being loaded with salt by the trembling, ghastly thin arms of skeletal slaves. In Taghaza, even the toughest slaves never survived more than a year; their owners didn't care if their lived or died: it was cheaper to keep buying new slaves every year, than to give the current slaves proper food, water and shelter. Maghan knew he would never be able to eat salt again without being haunted by the image of these moving skeletons with skin peeling off their bones. When their dead bodies were dumped into the trenches that they had dug themselves, no flesh was left for the scavengers to feast upon. If Hell exists, the prince thought, it can't be worse than Taghaza. Yet despite its dark qualities, that town was white and sparkling, being built entirely out of salt blocks. It had salt walls, salt houses and even a salt mosque with a salt minaret. It was a town that tasted like tears.

The governor's mansion was the largest salt house in Taghaza. Musa and Maghan were received at the entrance by a dry, beetle-like creature who was the vice-governor. The governor himself seldom set foot in Taghaza. He preferred to live in another city called Oualata, away from the stench of his duties. The way the vice-governor uttered a welcome, it was clear that his humanity had long melted away, leaving a dried-out carcass. When the mansa gave him the order to load his caravan with enough salt to last to Timbuktu, the man grinned and made a greedy gesture. Musa sighed and handed the man a purse full of gold. Taghaza was a part of his empire, but too remote to rule with full authority, and too important to risk seeing it fall into other hands. After the deal was settled and the sun had sunk below the bleak horizon, servants started preparing a small feast for the mansa, the prince, the vice-governor and the rich salt-buyer from Oualata who owned the merchant caravan. The three men and the boy sat in silence, as a strong flagrance of meat started filling the room. Maghan felt guilt enjoying this mouth-watering smell in such a context. He was sitting facing the window, looking at the dark blue sky and thinking of those slaves outside who wouldn't live to see many more sunrises. He was about to be served meat that had been preserved using the salt they had mined.

'O great Musa, I am your humble servant', the merchant suddenly said, uncomfortable in the silence. 'How was your pilgrimage to the noble Hedjaz?'

'It is done', was Musa's only answer, barely looking at the man.

'How praiseworthy of you to undergo it! You are indeed the greatest ruler in Africa. How did you find Egypt?'

'Better than how we left it.'

‘Is sultan Al-Nasir still imposing tariffs on imported slaves? For now, my only business is buying salt here to sell it back in Oualata, but I’m thinking about entering the slave trade, and selling to Egypt.’

‘Sultan Al-Nasir has been deposed.’

‘Ah! Was he deposed because of a famine or another calamity? If so, it might be more lucrative now than ever to sell them gold!’

‘I wouldn’t recommend it.’

The meat was served. Maghan found after a few bites that his hunger was greater than his shame and started swallowing the greasy meat eagerly. Musa also seemed enlivened by the food, as he started questioning the merchant about the state of business in the empire during his absence.

‘Very good, very good, your majesty! Your brother Suleiman is quite a stern man, I hear, but he has been ruling Mali smoothly as regent, not interfering too much with us businessmen. In Oualata, people are happy, as I’m sure is everyone else in the empire. It was a most excellent choice to give him the reins, your majesty.’

‘What is the current exchange rate of salt for slaves?’

‘It is most praiseworthy of you to ask! As the market stands today, the—Did you hear that?’

They’d all heard it. It sounded like beasts being hunted. The vice-governor shrugged and stretched his hand to grab more meat. He was used to those sounds. Maghan, on the other hand, kept staring through the window, until his heart froze. The swollen red eyes were the first thing he saw. Next, the sledgehammer tainted with blood. The slave jumped through the frame with a strident shriek and landed behind the vice-governor’s back. ‘How did that one get here?’ was the last thing the official said before his turned-around face was slashed in half. Then the sunburnt black skeleton turned to the prince. From his heart visibly pumping through his fleshless ribcage, it was clear the sight of a boy confused him. Taking advantage of that moment of confusion, Musa leapt to the attacker and grabbed both his arms. The sledgehammer fell from the slave’s hand. They wrestled hard. When the corpse-like man realized he was losing, he sank his remaining teeth into the mansa’s forearm. Musa had to let go and step back, clutching his bitten flesh. The slave didn’t waste a moment to pick up the sledgehammer. Maghan watched as his father was about to be struck. He was still sitting holding his clay plate, frozen with terror. Suddenly he jumped to his feet. His plate had shown him destruction and death – its future ready to be fulfilled.

When the guards rushed inside the room much too late, they found the slave fallen dead on the floor, his skull broken inwards; the vice-governor was slouched near him, just as dead; the merchant from Oualata was hiding behind a chest, shaking with fear; Maghan was still holding a bit of shattered clay from what had been his plate, bewildered at what he’d just done; Musa was squeezing his forearm, trying to keep the blood from oozing out. The guards immediately helped him back to his camp, with Maghan following along at running pace. Inside the royal tent, a crowd of healers gathered around the mansa, examining his wound and squabbling about what to do. Musa expelled them all but one, the most senior; once that healer was done bandaging his arm, he ordered him out as well.

‘Are you wounded?’, Musa asked his son once they were left alone.

‘No, father.’

‘Good, at least that… *thing* didn’t get you.’

Musa paused. His voice was strong, but only through a painful effort.

‘Maghan, what I said out of Cairo – I’m taking it back. Savviness can be learned; bravery cannot. Now go and tell all my ministers to come here as witnesses. I’ll be formally naming you as my successor. My brother Suleiman will act as regent until you reach adulthood. He’ll teach you how to rule.’

‘Father, what do you mean by this?’

‘You know what I mean.’

‘But that healer said—’

‘His mouth says something, but his eyes scream something else. As mansa, you must learn to read people’s eyes, if you want to decipher the truth from the flatteries. My arm’s already infected. Thanks to you I didn’t die tonight, but I doubt I’ll last until we reach Timbuktu. Praised be Allah, I’ve lived to complete my pilgrimage.’

Chapter 13

The man walked forward with a slow gait, not knowing what attitude suited such a high place. He had waited long hours since dawn, lost in a crowd of other plaintiffs until, moments before dusk, they finally called his name. Halfway across the courtyard, he stopped next to a crier. At the other end of the courtyard, he was faced with the wall of a domed room, windowless but for a few spearhead-shaped slits at the top. The warm light of sunset gave the stones the aspect of frozen fire. That impenetrable wall somehow struck the man with more awe and terror than if he had seen the mansa sitting on his throne behind it. As etiquette demanded, he threw himself on the ground and grabbed a handful of dust to spill on his naked head. Now came the time for him to speak the words he (and his whole village) had carefully prepared. He had repeated those words to himself over and over for the two whole days it had taken him to ride to Timbuktu.

‘O mansa, please hear my true story. As I was walking in my field, I caught a conversation between two locusts; they were talking about how worried they were that the tax-collector that comes to my village, by taking more millet than he should under the your law, risked starving the farmers and thus, with no one left to cultivate the fields, starving them poor locusts too.’

The crier repeated what the peasant had said loudly enough to be heard beyond the blind wall. Then silence filled the courtyard. Beads of sweat damped the dust on the peasant’s forehead. It had seemed a good idea to place his complaint in the mouths of locusts to avoid being held responsible for any offense, but now… The voice of another crier finally answered from inside the domed room. Mansa Maghan said that he had also heard of ants complaining about this specific tax-collector today. He would therefore launch an inquiry about him. The plaintiff stood, bowed and went, leaving his place for the next.

After ten more such audiences, the sun set, and Maghan's workday was finally over. Under the dome, he slowly stood up from his throne, exhausted by the weight of a whole empire's share of complaints, disputes and injustices. Qassa handed him a cup of hibiscus tea.

'You've done well today', she said. 'Your father would be proud.'

'He'd be prouder of *you*. Without you, there was at least a dozen complaints I wouldn't have known how to answer today.'

'Today it was a dozen, yesterday it was more, and tomorrow it will be none. You won't need me very soon – though I sure hope you'll keep your dear aunt around even then. I love solving the people's problems with you.'

'I'm sure that the very day you won't be here with me, that's when someone will bring me an impossible problem.'

'Well, dear nephew', Qassa chuckled, 'if that problem will be impossible, then even I won't be able to solve it!'

Maghan smiled and raised his eyes to her. With her glorious hair and proud demeanor, she looked much more a mansa than he did. Although he didn't admit it to himself, her sight stung him with jealously. Qassa had been the closest figure he ever had to a mother since queen Inari's passing, yet her presence made him a little more uncomfortable each day. As they were walking side by side out of the throne room and through the palace complex, neither of them failed to notice the side looks from court officials. *Why has she rejected every marriage alliance for the young mansa, if not for fear he might fall under another woman's influence?* a pair of eyes seemed to ask. *Why has Qassa named her husband Suleiman as general to fight in faraway campaigns, if not to keep him out of her way to power*? another seemed to wonder. There were also rumors about the nature of the aunt and nephew's relationship, as vulgar as they were false. Maghan tried his best not to let it affect him, though he knew that had he been an official, he'd have whispered along with the others. Qassa was the mansa of Mali in all but name, and the whole court knew it. Thankfully, audiences happened from opposite sides of a blind wall, shielding the mansa from view. The old mansas had devised audiences this way to make their sanctions impersonal, in the name of the people of Mali; to Maghan, however, it was also a convenient way for the people not to see that Qassa was the one answering most complaints.

'Tomorrow morning', Qassa said in equal tone, 'it would be appropriate for you be at the gates when your uncle Suleiman returns from the war and be the first to congratulate him on his victory.'

'I will… of course.'

They were now in the most private part of the palace, out of reach from most ears. Maghan could finally speak his mind.

'Aunt Qassa, why isn't it me returning from war tomorrow? Why does Suleiman reap all the glory, while I stay here like… like a *weakling*.' Maghan cringed hearing himself saying that term. The words of Al-Nasir calling him unworthy daily replayed in his mind since he inherited the throne.

'Suleiman is the army commander, and you are the mansa. To each his role, to each his victories.'

'But there are no victories to my name.'

‘We’ve talked about this many times already. Just look at the state of the empire. Our harvests have never had a higher yield, and our coffers have never been fuller.’

‘These are *your* victories.’

‘Tell me, Maghan: if you had been another kind of man – a man like my husband Suleiman – would I even have victories to score?’

‘I believe you would, Qassa. You are strong. When Suleiman becomes mansa after me, I know you will retain a lot of power.’

‘Why do you keep saying Suleiman will become mansa after you?’

‘I… I just have this intuition.’

‘You almost make it sound like a wish. Be careful, or you will attract the evil eye.’

They parted after this. Maghan wished he could tell her about his ability but doubted whether he could trust her given the content of his latest visions: he had foreseen Suleiman sitting on the throne as mansa and taking advice from his wife Qassa, with neither of them mourning him. When and why Qassa would betray him to hand power to her husband, he hadn’t been able to gather.

When Suleiman appeared at the gates of Timbuktu, he was accompanied by huge warriors riding in perfect formation, with white skin, red hair or narrow eyes. Maghan had never seen Mamluks in this part of the world. He tried not to look confused. Perhaps his uncle had sent him a messenger to inform him about those Mamluks, but that messenger had disappeared en route to Timbuktu… Suleiman steered his tall warhorse uncomfortably close to Maghan’s own Arabian mare.

‘O Suleiman Keita, my dear uncle, welcome home!’, the young mansa declaimed, going on to recite a speech congratulating his uncle for his victory against the Tuareg tribe who was raiding caravans from Morocco. All the while, he was looking beyond his uncle’s shoulders to the Mamluk regiment.

‘Please, my dear nephew, I do not deserve so many praises! You seem keen to meet my friends, so I’ll introduce them at once!’ Suleiman turned to the foremost Mamluk. ‘Here is Temur, the trusted emissary of the Mamluk sultan, who comes with a letter from the blessed hand of our beloved caliph. When he and his brave regiment arrived at my camp near Oualata, I had the honor invite them to join our campaign. We quickly grew close like brothers, have we not?’ Suleiman and Temur complicitly nodded at each other. ‘Temur teased me he could crush the Tuaregs with his regiment alone, but I wouldn’t let him steal me any glory. So, I took my best soldiers, in equal number to Temur’s men, and we made a contest of who would kill the most enemies. After we won the battle, which we fought outnumbered and uphill, we compared our counts – it was a tie! Those Mamluks really are the world’s finest warriors, as they say—Oh, but I almost forgot about the letter. It was addressed to me, Suleiman Keita, but I thought you must read it too.’

‘Dear uncle’, Maghan asked, trying to keep his voice from trembling, ‘if a letter has been addressed to you by the caliph, why didn’t you inform me at once?’

‘When you read the letter, you’ll understand why I had to deliver it to you myself.’

Suleiman handed Maghan a fine metallic box covered with hunting scenes, made by some mediocre coppersmith. The scroll Maghan found inside the box indeed bore the black seal of the Abbasid

caliphs. It read: ‘We, caliph Al-Wathiq of the House of Abbas, commander of the believers, are hereby recognizing faithful Muslim Suleiman Keita as the rightful mansa of Mali. May Allah help him to a fair and peaceful reign.’ Maghan’s blood turned cold.

‘What happened to him? What happened to caliph Al-Mustakfi?’

‘That fat bookworm?’ Temur replied, riding menacingly close to Maghan. ‘He died. Now his son is our beloved caliph.’

‘How did he die?’

‘What does it matter to you? You’d better be concerned about yourself, boy. The caliph has spoken against you.’

‘But Al-Mustakfi’s son is eight years old! I don’t understand… Why would Baybars do this?’

‘Baybars?’ Temur shrugged. ‘He died too.’

‘Then who is the new sultan?’

‘There is no *new* sultan. Baybars and Al-Mustakfi should have known better than naming Al-Nasir governor of Aleppo, instead of eliminating him. Did they think he’d quietly settle down in Aleppo? Not our great sultan! He rallied the Syrian Mamluks his cause and marched on Cairo. The Citadel fell in a matter of days, and you can guess what happened to your friends after that!’ Temur chuckled and turned to Suleiman. ‘Brother, if I were you, I wouldn’t make the same mistake as Baybars. Never let an enemy live to take his revenge.’

‘My brother Musa was the greatest mansa ever to rule Mali’, said Suleiman. ‘I respected him deeply. For his sake, I can’t have his son killed. I’ll banish him instead. If he dares to come back – let him try and defeat us.’

‘Ha!’

Maghan chuckle at first, then broke out in uncontrolled laughter. Temur and Suleiman both stared at him with deep disgust.

‘What’s the matter with this one?’, asked the Mamluk.

‘It’s not…’, Maghan mumbled, taking back control of himself. ‘It’s that… I was sure I would die! Thank you for… well… All these years, I thought you’d kill me. And I thought Qassa would betray me, too.’

Suleiman frowned, and Maghan understood he had said too much.

‘You sound like your grandfather. Musa believed our father was just a madman, but I think he could really see the future – damned be his soul! Only the demons can give man such a cursed power. Did the demons get you too?’

Maghan panicked and, without thought, stirred his horse sideways and into a gallop. He didn’t get very far until Temur caught up to him, yanked away the reins from his hands and grabbed him by the throat. Maghan gasped.

‘Can you really see the future?’, Temur asked him with an odd smile. ‘Can you? Oh, stop struggling like that! I asked a simple question’

Maghan nodded despite himself. Without releasing him, the Mamluk laughed.

‘Yes? And you dared lecture sultan Al-Nasir about free will, when you know the future is written in advance? Free will is an illusion, and you hypocrite knew it!’

Maghan tried to answer, but the large hand was squeezing his vocal cords too tightly.

‘Let him speak’, Suleiman said. ‘I’m curious about what he has to say.’

Set free from the Mamluk’s grip, Maghan caught his breath and composed himself. He knew that his reply, though it might cost him his life, was worth more than his mere survival. All the questions that haunted him since the pilgrimage were about to hear their answer. He cleared his throat.

‘The future may already be written, but ask yourself: would you feel the difference, if the future was written or not? Would it change what is right or what is wrong? Would it change how we plan our lives or behave towards others? No, it wouldn’t. Therefore, what does it matter? Those who, like yourself, insist that free will is but an illusion, are never doing it as philosophers; your goal is not intellectual pursuit, but oppression. Why would anyone insist to his peers that free will is worthless, if not to justify taking it away from them? It’s unfortunate that freedom is like gold: only once it becomes scarce, do people realize how precious it is. Freedom is much more precious than any amount of gold, however. In fact, it is more valuable than life itself. Because we may be the mere readers of a life written for us, but which book would you rather read: an exciting story of adventure, or the boring inventory of routine days? I pick the former. The latter isn’t worth reading. I won’t let anyone convince me that, because my free will is an illusion, I must watch myself spend the rest of my life head down, suppressing my thoughts and desires. The whole of mankind might choose that mere state of existence, but I won’t follow the pack – because I have free will. If you want me to hand you my freedom – you can get on your knees and beg for it. And if you want to take my freedom away by force – you can come and get it!’

Temur chuckled. He pulled his sword a few inches out of his scabbard and turned to Suleiman.

‘Should I come and get it?’

Suleiman sighed. ‘Let him be. He is Musa’s son, indeed. If he wants his life to be an exciting adventure story, what good would it do to me not to let him live it?’

Epilogue

‘Father, did I do something that upset you?’

‘No, Djata’, Maghan sighed. ‘But you’re staying on this ship.’

‘But father! It’s my first time in Zanj, I want to see—’

‘Not here, Djata, not in this cursed port. Can you promise me you won’t try anything stupid?’

‘Yes, father, I promise.’

Maghan turned around heavy hearted. Every time they reached a new destination, the spark of curiosity in Djata’s eyes reminded him of his own child self and filled him with pride. But this time he had to extinguish this spark. They had just landed in Zanzibar, and he couldn’t bear the thought of pure, joyful little Djata inside that infamous city where, many years ago, his one-time friends had been brought in chains.

Upon disembarking, he was met with custom agents asking him which good he intended to sell in Zanzibar. *None* was his cold reply. He was here to buy supplies and leave. Together with his best men, he ventured into the city. As he had expected, every street reeked of the slave trade, the scent of sweat and filth. At each turn, he feared to meet old ghosts. After a restless day, he and his men returned to the ship with enough food and freshwater to resume the journey southward. When Maghan ordered his sailors to set sail again the next day at sunrise, they protested: they had just sailed the monsoon winds all the way from Guangzhou – couldn't they rest a few days? Maghan persuaded them with a bonus gold coin each. He was impatient to leave Zanzibar, but also to reach his destination – a mysterious realm beyond the edge of the known world.

Sailing down along the Zanj coast, they quickly arrived at Kilwa, a proud town built of coral rock. Dawud, the local sultan, greeted them in person when they landed. Trade was the life and blood of Kilwa, so he treated each arriving merchant like a lord, even inviting them to stay in his palace. Maghan introduced himself as *Maghan al-Mali*, rather than *Maghan Keita*, hiding his high birth as he always did to avoid both the favors and troubles it attracted. During the welcome feast, Maghan inquired Dawud about any kingdom that lay further south.

'There is no such kingdom', the sultan said hurriedly.

'Are you sure? I have heard about a great pagan realm. Its capital has strong grey stone walls – or so I've been told.'

The sultan's smiling mask suddenly dropped, as seemed the temperature in the coral hall.

'Who told you about it?', he asked coldly.

'I… don't remember', Maghan said, confused at the abrupt change of mood.

'Then I order you to remember his name and tell it to me quickly.'

Though no swords were drawn, the unsheathing sound of his executioner's blade could be heard in the sultan's voice. Maghan instinctively put a protective hand around Djata's shoulders. He now guessed that the sheer existence of this kingdom must be kept a secret by Kilwa to maintain its trade monopoly. Sultan Dawud would have been relieved to learn that no one had betrayed this secret, because it had appeared to that Malian merchant in a vision, but he'd never have believed it. Maghan thought fast.

'When I was in Zanzibar, I stumbled upon a sailor who had been shipwrecked far to the south. He told me that he had heard of a great inland kingdom, but nothing else. As you know, many sailors whimsically tell tales of great cities and kingdoms, and some even swear to have seen them with their own eyes. I only asked you about it to make conversation – but I don't believe in such fantasies.'

'Neither should you', Dawud concluded with a skeptical frown.

After this incident, Maghan knew better than to linger too long in Kilwa. Not to arouse suspicions, he sold some of his goods here but kept the best part for the city with the gray stone walls. His men mingled with the locals, trying to gather intelligence on what lay south of Kilwa. The locals did not betray the secret about the inland realm, but they did mention a coastal city called Sofala, which

they claimed to be the southernmost port in the world. Beyond that, some said, lay the island of Waqwaq, populated solely by women, who grow on trees like fruits and slaughter any man who lands on their shore. Upon hearing of Sofala, Maghan remembered the large world map that Al-Mustakfi had once unfolded for him at the Citadel library; the boy he was had spent a whole day running his fingers through the most distant and exotic lands; and he recalled, at the bottom of the world, a tiny dot named Sofala.

Sailing there proved long and hard. The ship had to stay away from the coast to avoid being spotted, and the unknown waters were perilous even to experienced sailors, full of hull-breaking rocks. It was the middle of summer, yet an icy wind was blowing. Djata asked his father why it was growing colder and was amazed to learn that in the Southern Hemisphere, the seasons are inverted, and why it is so.

When they finally reached in Sofala, the travelers marveled at its wealth. Its markets abounded with ivory, leopard skin, and so much gold it reminded the fallen mansa of his long-lost homeland. Clearly, it was trading with a rich neighbor. After much asking around and bribing, Maghan was introduced to a good-natured merchant coming from the mysterious inland kingdom, where he was about to return with his caravan. Both men did not speak any language in common, yet they managed to agree upon a price for joining the caravan. Maghan watched as carts were loaded with boxes full of porcelain, jade and tea leaves bought in Guangzhou, remembering the visions these goods had given him: a genial king asking him if the blue dragons depicted on the porcelain really fly the skies of China; a red-robed priestess giggling as she tries a jade necklace on; a little prince spitting out his first sip of tea because it is too bitter… and all around them, massive curved walls of gray stone[19]. Despite that place being so far away, and outside of any map, he hadn't been able to resist his desire – and his destiny – to travel there. He thought with irony that the goods were carrying the merchant, not the other way around.

As the caravan was about to depart, and Maghan was busy adjusting the saddle and harness of horses, a ghastly thin slave child in rags came pulling Djata's sleeve. Djata took out a gold coin from his purse and, after a pause, handed it to the little girl, who grabbed it and ran without a word.

'Djata', Maghan said with a frown, 'why did you give her that coin?'

'She looked hungry.'

'Sometimes receiving gold can be a curse more than a blessing. Haven't I told you what happened in Cairo?'

'Yes, father. Many times.'

'Then you should know better than to give money away to anyone that looks hungry.' He peered down the dark alley where the child had vanished. 'That girl might run into trouble because of you.'

'She won't, father. With the coin I just gave her, she'll buy her freedom from her master.'

'How do you know?'

Djata smiled. 'The gold told me.'

19 The Great Zimbabwe was, like Mali, one of the great civilisations of medieval Africa. The monumental stone ruins it left behind gave the modern country of Zimbabwe its name, meaning *stone house*. It had vanished before the arrival of Europeans, who couldn't believe such massive walls had been built by the native people.

THE END[20]

20 This story ends here, but History goes on: in 1360, Djata would return to Mali and, with the help of Qassa, lead a rebellion against Suleiman's son to take the throne. Today, the name Keita is bore by hundreds of thousands of Malians, the descendants of the mansas of old. The founding father of the modern state of Mali was a Keita. The legacy of Musa and Maghan lives on.